HT MUMBAI, NEW DELHI, BENGALURU, KOLKATA, CHENNAI, AHMEDABAD, HYDERABAD, PUNE*

Monday, March 9, 2026

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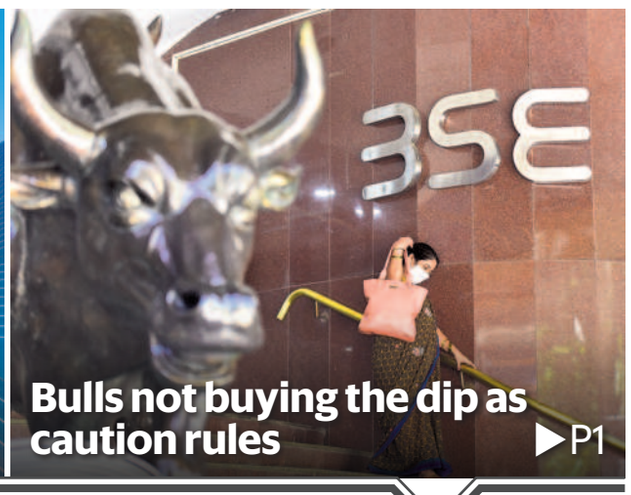
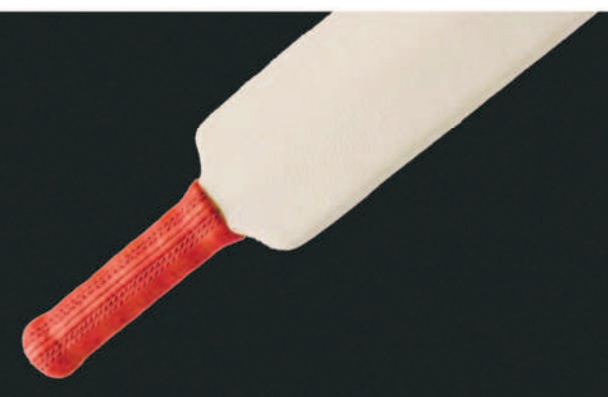
livemint.com

Sembcorp, Hexa circle Enel's India green unit ▶P1



Bulls not buying the dip as caution rules ▶P1



20% higher watchtime on non-live sports content vs live

YouTube ROI is 3x of OTT and 2.4x of TV

There's only one YouTube

Source
1. Google commissioned Kantar Sports Fan Research 2024, Deloitte analysis.
2. In an MMM meta-analysis we commissioned with Nielsen, on average, YouTube effectiveness was 24.11 times greater than Linear TV effectiveness across Total CPG MMMs that measured YouTube, Other Digital, and Linear TV from Jan'20- Sep'23 in India. According to a meta analysis of CPG MMM Studies by Analytic Edge in India, YouTube ROI was 3.0x of OTT Platforms ROI (2021-2024)

HT MUMBAI, NEW DELHI, BENGALURU, KOLKATA, CHENNAI, AHMEDABAD, HYDERABAD, PUNE* VOL. 9 NO. 58

Monday, March 9, 2026

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Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

How RBI plans to compensate for digital frauds

BY SUBHANA SHAIKH

The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has proposed a framework to partly compensate victims of small-value digital payment fraud even if they were partly responsible. The benefit may be capped and limited to a one-time claim. How could the mechanism work and why does the RBI believe that a shared liability framework is needed? *Mint* explains:

Persistent concern

Amid India's rapid shift to digital payments, RBI wants to ensure quicker relief for customers who fall prey to cyber fraud.

Cards/internet frauds based on the date of reporting.

	Number of frauds*	Amount (in ₹ crore)
FY23	6,699	277
FY24	29,080	1,457
FY25	13,469	520
FY26**	195	14

*refers to cases of ₹1 lakh and above. **FY26 data as of September 2025.

Source: Report on Trend and Progress of Banking in India 2024-25, Reserve Bank of India

mint

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

1 What has the RBI proposed in its new framework on digital payment fraud compensation?

The RBI has proposed a framework to compensate victims of small-value digital payment frauds, even in cases where the customer may have been partly negligent. The draft guidelines allow partial reimbursement for transactions of up to ₹50,000, with victims potentially receiving up to 85% of the loss or up to ₹25,000, whichever is lower. The benefit may be available only once in a lifetime for each customer. The idea is to create a structured compensation mechanism where the financial burden is shared among the issuing bank, receiving bank and, potentially, the regulator, ensuring quicker relief for customers who fall prey to cyber fraud.

TURN TO PAGE 06

QUICK EDIT

War: Odds and ends

Global prediction markets have evoked much interest after the Iran war broke out. On Polymarket, a platform for stablecoin bets on various outcomes, "Will the Iranian regime fall by June 30?" was offering users a 'Yes' token for 34 US cents and a 'No' one for 67 cents on Sunday. These prices reflect this online market's view of the stated event's probability. If the broadly defined 'regime' isn't toppled by this wager's deadline, the tokens of No-holders will 'resolve' to $1 each while Yes-holders get nothing. As these prices change in line with perceptions, bet holders can sell their chips anytime before it gets resolved one way or the other. While such markets capture money-backed opinions and enrich what we know, they are controversial. Suspicions of insider trading have shadowed recently resolved bets on armed US action against Iran. In general, leaks from people in the loop of big decisions don't just distort crystal-ball markets, their profit upside could create perverse incentives to make a killing, as it were, on high-stake events. If war is too serious a matter to be left to generals, let alone AI, we can only hope that crypto punters never get a say in world affairs of consequence.

PLAIN FACTS

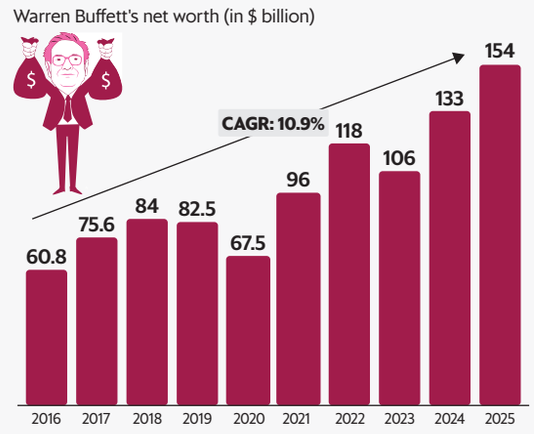
BUFFETT, ABEL & THE BERKSHIRE PARADOX

BY HOWINDIALIVES.COM

When Berkshire Hathaway published its latest financial results, it attracted more than the usual attention for two reasons. First, the fourth-quarter and full-year earnings reports present the final report card for Warren Buffett's era as the conglomerate's chief executive officer (CEO). Second, it featured the highly anticipated debut shareholder letter from the company's new CEO, Greg Abel, who is inheriting a formidable legacy. Abel finds himself in a tough spot—he cannot deviate from the path set by Buffett, which has greatly benefited investors. Yet, with Berkshire sitting on a cash pile of nearly $373 billion, the new chief executive is under pressure to show more aggression.

By the end of 2025, Warren Buffett's net worth exceeded $150 billion

Warren Buffett's net worth (in $ billion)



Source: Forbes

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REMARKABLE LEGACY

YEAR 2025 marked a key transition at Berkshire Hathaway. Buffett stepped down as CEO after 60 years, announcing the decision at the company's annual shareholder meeting in May, citing the effects of ageing.

He took control of Berkshire in 1965 when it was a struggling textile manufacturer. With his partner Charlie Munger, who died in 2023, he built it into a sprawling conglomerate with holdings in insurance, railroads, energy, utilities, consumer goods, and manufacturing, valued at $1.05 trillion in early 2026.

Between 1965 and 2025, Berkshire's shares delivered a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of approximately 19.8%, compared with roughly 10% for the S&P 500, including dividends. This translates to a total return more than 60,000 times the initial investment, compared with 400-460 times for the index. By the end of 2025, his own net worth exceeded $150 billion. This track record made Buffett one of the most revered investors in history.

MUTED FINALE

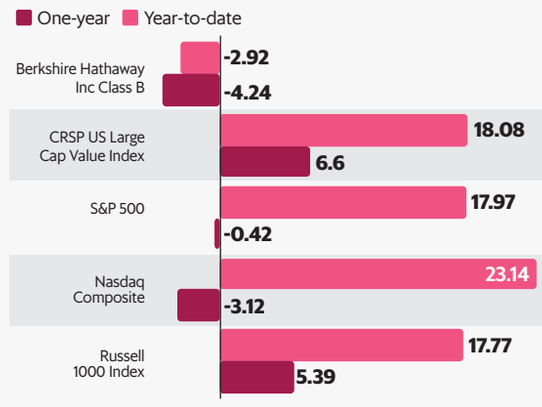
BUFFETT's FINALE did not reflect his lifetime of achievement. In Q4 2025, Berkshire's operating earnings fell nearly 30% year-on-year to $10.2 billion, primarily driven by insurance. Underwriting profits plummeted 54% to $1.56 billion, while insurance investment income dropped roughly 25% to $3.1 billion. Geico saw underwriting profit fall by nearly half, due to rising accident claims and higher advertising expenses.

Abel flagged challenges, noting that after years of rate increases, the industry is experiencing deceleration amid increased competition from new capital. Given Berkshire's strict underwriting discipline, he cautioned that this "likely means we will write less property and casualty business for a period of time".

Still, Berkshire's diversification offered some cushion. BNSF railroad posted a 6% increase in Q4 profit, and the manufacturing, service, and retail segment recorded a 3% gain. However, overall net income fell about 3% to $19.2 billion in the quarter.

Over the past year, Berkshire Hathaway's Class B shares have underperformed the markets

Change (in %) in share/indices

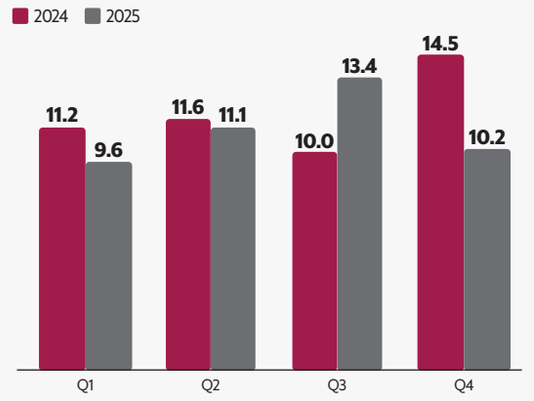


Source: Google Finance

mint

Berkshire Hathaway saw its operating earnings drop in three quarters in 2025

Berkshire Hathaway's operating earnings (in $ million)



Source: Berkshire Hathaway financial statements

mint

FADING PREMIUM

AFTER BUFFETT announced he would step down, Berkshire's shares fell sharply from their record high of over $809,000. The stock lost up to 14% over the following months through early August, even as the S&P 500 gained about 11% over the same period, creating the widest three-month underperformance gap relative to the index in decades. Analysts attributed the sell-off to the unwinding of the "Buffett premium", as long-term holders, including families and early investors who had held shares for generations, chose to exit ahead of the leadership change.

On the Monday following the Q4 2025 earnings release, Berkshire shares fell nearly 5%, pushing the stock into negative territory for the year. The immediate trigger was the 30% drop in operating earnings, but the sell-off was compounded by investor frustration over Abel's decision to maintain the pause on share buybacks while reaffirming the company's long-standing refusal to pay a dividend.

CONTINUITY PLEDGE

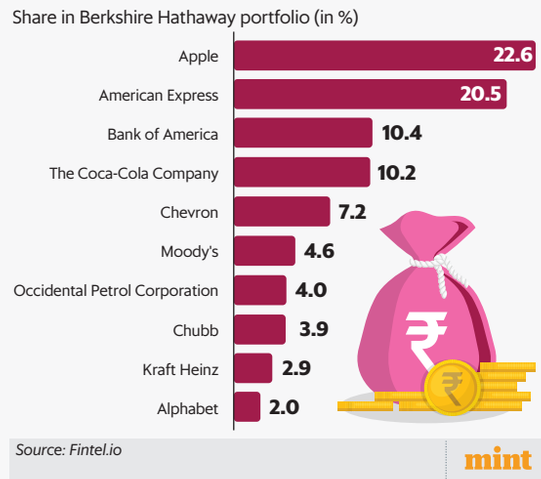
IN HIS inaugural CEO letter, Abel said Berkshire's values and financial conservatism "remain unchanged and will continue into perpetuity." He assured to uphold Buffett and Munger's legacy, promising subsidiaries autonomy while sticking to Buffett's playbook: a strong balance sheet, limited debt, and patient capital allocation.

These principles guided Berkshire into building its current portfolio (see chart). Abel said he expects the core holdings to compound over decades and intends to hold "preferably forever". Buybacks will only occur when shares trade below a conservative estimate of intrinsic value, and the long-standing resistance to paying a cash dividend will remain firmly in place.

Framing his tenure as a long-term commitment, Abel acknowledged he cannot realistically match Buffett's 60-year run, but set a clear benchmark. Twenty years from now, shareholders and their descendants will find Berkshire stronger than they left it.

Berkshire has been top-heavy; just four shares account for 60% its portfolio

Share in Berkshire Hathaway portfolio (in %)



Source: Fintel.io

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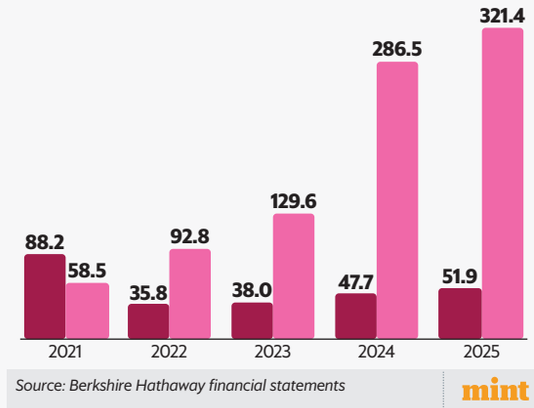
Berkshire's cash pile has surged in recent years to nearly $373 billion in 2025

Berkshire Hathaway's cash pile (in $ billion)



Source: Berkshire Hathaway financial statements

mint

CASH PUZZLE

BERKSHIRE HATHAWAY's shares fell nearly 5% after its earnings report, partly due to investor frustration over its near-record cash pile and concerns that CEO Greg Abel may not deploy it aggressively.

Berkshire ended 2025 with $373.3 billion in cash and short-term US Treasury bills. Abel described the reserve as dry powder supporting a "fortress-like balance sheet". He said a portion of it was earmarked to back Berkshire's insurance operations, and the rest for deployment.

Berkshire's biggest deal in three years was a $9.7 billion all-cash acquisition of OxyChem, Occidental Petroleum's petrochemicals unit. Abel also cited the purchase of Bell Laboratories, a family-owned rodent-control firm, as the type of business Berkshire seeks: durable economics, strong managers and no financing contingencies.

He promised that Berkshire will evaluate deals and move quickly when they meet its criteria.

www.howindialives.com is a database and search engine for public data.

HT MUMBAI, NEW DELHI, BENGALURU, KOLKATA, CHENNAI, AHMEDABAD, HYDERABAD, PUNE* VOL. 9 NO. 58 Rs. 12.00 18 PAGES

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Why Instamart is playing Noice ▶P10

Investors want stability, India gives: Carnelian's Khemani ▶P4

Sembcorp, Hexa circle Enel's India green unit

Sale likely at $300 mn enterprise value; deal after sale to Waree fell through

Utpal Bhaskar
utpal.b@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

The Indian renewable energy business of Sembcorp Industries Ltd as well as Hexa Climate Solutions are vying for the entire India renewable business of Italy's Enel Group in a deal having an equity and enterprise value of around $100 million and $300 million, respectively, according to two people aware of the development. Singapore's Sembcorp is present in India through Sembcorp India Pvt. Ltd and Sembcorp Green Infra Ltd (SGIL) along with other subsidiaries, while Hexa is backed by I Squared Capital.

The HSBC-run sale process follows a deal signed last year—which later fell through—under which Waaree Energies Ltd had agreed to buy 100% of Enel Green Power India Pvt Ltd (EGP India) from its parent Enel Green Power Development S.R.L. for ₹792 crore. *Mint* first reported on 15 November 2023 that Enel Group planned to exit its India renewable business.

"Enel Group's entire India renewable business is back on offer again and Sembcorp and Hexa are in talks for it," one of the two people cited above said, requesting anonymity.

Enel Green Power India's portfolio comprises 760 megawatts (MW) of operational wind and solar assets, and a development pipeline of 2.5 gigawatts (GW). The company has been present in India's renewable sector since 2015. In 2020, it partnered with Norway's state-owned investment fund Norfund to jointly finance, build and operate new renewable projects in the country.

Enel Group had earlier also explored opportunities in India's power distribution sector, including the proposed privatization of Puducherry's electricity utility. It had also submitted non-binding offers earlier to acquire Reliance Infrastructure Ltd's Delhi electricity distribution businesses.

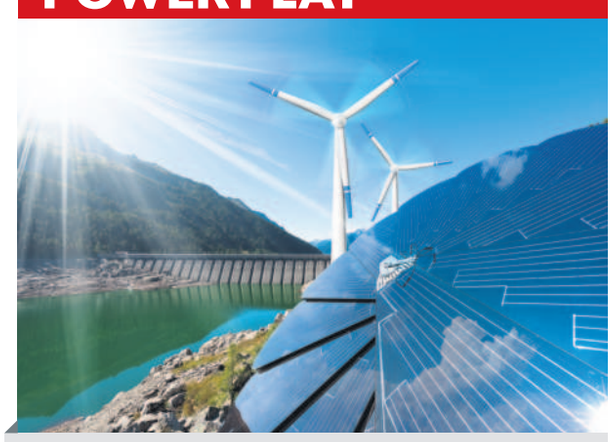
The development comes as both Sembcorp and Hexa are ramping up their India portfolios.

Last year, Sembcorp acquired 300MW of solar projects from Nasdaq-listed ReNew Energy Global Plc. The Singapore Exchange-listed company currently has a renewable portfolio of

TURN TO PAGE 9

ISTOCKPHOTO

POWER PLAY



RENEWABLE RACE

ENEL'S portfolio has 760MW of wind, solar assets

THE company has been present in India since 2015

IT had earlier eyed bets in India's power distribution

DON'T MISS

India eyes chip autonomy

India is working to become independent in designing and producing microchips under its semiconductor mission, while attracting professionals with MNC experience. >P2

War pops wheat export dreams

The conflict in West Asia may stall India's return to the global wheat market, just as the rabi harvest is to hit markets later this month in a setback to farmers and traders. >P2

NOTE TO READERS The Media Marketing Initiative on Page 3 is the equivalent of a paid-for advertisement and no *Mint* journalist was involved in creating it. Readers would do well to treat it as an advertisement.

Bulls not buying the dip as caution rules

Ram Sahgal
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MUMBAI

When stock markets tank, intrepid investors troop in to buy the dip. This time, though, the signs are missing.

With the Iran attack widening into a regional conflict, investor sentiment remains significantly subdued, raising the possibility of further market declines. The flare-up threatens to block crude oil supplies from the region, and fuel a spike in energy prices.

The lack of interest among bulls is reflected by a sharp fall in the cumulative value of marketwide call options (index and stocks) relative to marketwide put options since the war began last Saturday. This, in turn, indicates investors are not buying the dip, a diversion from past occasions, and raises the chances of the Nifty falling as much as 2.7% to 23,800 unless the tensions abate, per analysts.

TURN TO PAGE 4

Lack of interest is seen in the sharp fall of call options. HT

New MF fee rules to hit small agents

Apoorva Ajith
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MUMBAI

A regulatory overhaul of how commissions are paid will shake up the segment estimated to account for about half of India's ₹81 trillion in mutual fund assets: small distributors. Industry experts say they will be forced to partner with larger peers to survive, driving consolidation.

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) in December approved a revised framework for total expense ratio (TER) limits. It has two components: the base expense ratio (BER) and all statutory and regulatory levies, such as goods and services tax (GST), securities transaction tax, stamp duty, and regulatory fees, which will be charged separately over and above the base cost.

For equity-oriented schemes, BER will now range from 2.10% for assets up to ₹500 crore to 0.95% for assets more than ₹50,000 crore. It

TURN TO PAGE 6

Sebi has approved a revised framework for TER limits. REUTERS

Parts firms take safe lane on green trip

Ayaan Kartik
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NEW DELHI

Auto component makers are pitching powertrain-agnostic portfolios as the best way to address uncertainty about which technologies will dominate roads amid the shift away from combustion engines.

Strategies put in place by companies like Greaves Cotton, Tenneco Clean Air and Belrise Industries suggest that suppliers need to either make parts that can be used across multiple powertrains or build capabilities simultaneously in electric, combustion, hybrid and CNG technologies.

The approach helps them stay relevant regardless of which technology leaps ahead, according to industry executives and experts. Their comments come as global carmakers such as Ford, Volkswagen and Stellantis slow their EV-only plans, while in India, automakers spar over policy priorities for EVs and transitional technologies like hybrids and CNG.

"You have to hedge your bets, or rather, you have to make sure you have activities in all [powertrains]. Even the OEMs are doing that," said Parag Satpute, managing director and chief executive at Greaves Cotton, known for engine manufacturing and engineering.

"As an auto component company, in some ways, it's easier for us to do that. We are dealing in components; so, there's not a huge difference in the components when it comes between, let's say a CNG or a diesel or a petrol. The components are fairly similar. Their capabilities are fairly similar," Satpute added.

India's premier energy efficiency agency, the Bureau of Energy Efficiency, has drawn up a clean fuel mix scenario for FY32 comprising multiple technologies, including hybrids, flex fuel vehicles, electric, CNG and traditional ICE engines, Mint reported on 20 February.

Arvind Chandra, chief executive at Tenneco Clean Air India, said the company will be prepared, no matter the course of technology evolution.

"What we're seeing at a high level is no matter how the pendulum swings, whether it swings to go back to full internal combustion engine, diesel, petrol vehicles, we are fine

TURN TO PAGE 9

Suppliers may now need to make parts that can be used across multiple powertrains. MINT

STRAIGHT FORWARD

SHASHI SHEKHAR

Respond to this column at
feedback@livemint.com

A 20-YR TRIP: FROM 7-DAY FAILURE TO LONG-TERM RULE

It was the month of March in the year 2000. Nitish Kumar was facing the Assembly leading a 7-day-old government. He needed a minimum of 12 legislators to prove his majority on the floor of the house. Had it been today, with 20 independents and 23 Congressmen it would have been a cakewalk but those were different times.

At that time in the legislative assembly Lalu Prasad Yadav's Rashtriya Janata Dal with 124 members was the largest force present in the hall. Nitish's Samata Party on the other hand had only 34 seats. He had the support of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and others with a total tally of 151. This support was the key that drove the governor to ask him to stake claim to the chief minister's post. Since Nitish became the chief minister rumours were rife that Lalu's close associate Shahabuddin had ringfenced 23 Congress MLAs. Despite being the chief minister Nitish was helpless. In a decade of his rule Lalu had uniquely modified the Bihar administration.

It was impossible to root out the 'system' in just seven days.

The inevitable happened and with an emotional speech Nitish Kumar bowed out of his first term in power. "Bihar's public is witnessing how democracy is being held hostage. Do we want to offer such politics to Bihar where even the public representatives aren't free to move about?" were his desperate words.

After this dramatic event Rabri Devi became the chief minister. Why? Lalu was in no mood to risk his position by offering the CM's post to any outsider. He knew the party could break. Today the same game is being played albeit with different players.

Since his decision to leave 1, Anne Marg, Nitish Kumar is doing exactly the same as his rivals did earlier. Lalu made his wife, who till the other day looked after the house, the CM, and Nitish had to bring his reticent son Nishant Kumar in politics.

However, the question remains, will Nishant be able to fill his father's boots? The other question is who would control the government in Bihar?

It's clear if the saffron party misses the chance this time, they'll regret it for time to come. The most important reason is that despite consistently winning more seats than JDU the highest they have ever aspired was for a deputy CM's post. The second problem is Sushil Modi's long, and successful tenure as the Bihar deputy CM stifled the growth of any big state leader in the BJP.

> The question everyone is asking: will Nishant Kumar be able to fill his father's boots?

There's a big section in Bihar that feels Nitish's third and fourth terms weren't that great. Rumours are doing the rounds about his health. At this juncture Nitish's decision to move to Rajya Sabha is a reflection of his political maturity.

Anyone from the BJP or the JDU, who moves into 1, Ane Marg will take a very long time to match the stature of Nitish Kumar. After a lot of efforts Nitish was able to bring Bihar out of the 'jungle raj'. As a journalist I have witnessed the sorry state of roads, decline of institutions and the shabby state of police stations in the state. Once I asked Nitish how he was able to make the turnaround? He replied, I had to deal with the problem at its root. He said when he came to power for the second time he found the police stations had vehicles but no fuel, people had to bring their own paper to lodge a complaint.

After pausing for a moment, Nitish Kumar said what can you expect when the police use outdated vehicles to carry out a raid and people bring their own paper to lodge a complaint? Similarly, untarred roads, potholes and an uncomfortable drive became synonymous with Bihar.

Nitish Kumar brought about a change. His cycle scheme gave wings to the girl child. Today women form 35% of the Bihar police force. There has been a phenomenal change in government offices and schools. A house and tap water for everyone, and electricity connection schemes have started. Some schemes reached fruition, some were not that successful but they acted in unison to bring Bihar out of the morass of bad governance it was in.

During this period Nitish made some harsh decisions. Prohibition was one of them. He solidified his women vote bank but also opened the flood gates to illicit and spurious liquor trade.

This would be the biggest challenge the new chief minister will have to deal with. He will not only have to emerge from the shadows of a huge leader who straddled Bihar's political arena for two decades but also deal with the wave of new expectations the last elections have raised.

Shashi Shekhar is editor-in-chief, Hindustan. *Views are personal.*

A bitter harvest for wheat as war pops export dreams

Exporters are wary of committing to large shipments as freight rates remain volatile

Dhirendra Kumar & Vijay C. Roy
NEW DELHI

The conflict in West Asia may stall India's return to the global wheat market, just as the rabi harvest is set to hit markets later this month. The development marks a setback for farmers and traders in the world's second-largest producer, which has reopened exports after nearly four years of restrictions.

Uncertainty in shipping logistics is affecting forward deals with importing countries as well as procurement plans with farmers. Exporters are wary of committing to large shipments, given that freight rates remain volatile and vessel schedules uncertain. The development assumes significance given that India's wheat production this financial year is expected to reach a record 120 million tonnes.

"With the crisis in West Asia intensifying, there is lacklustre sentiment among both importers and exporters due to higher freight costs and logistical uncertainties. Things are likely to be clear in due course of time," said Vikas Jain, proprietor, Osho Marketing House, a Delhi-based export firm.

"Though global wheat prices have increased, it could have been a good opportunity for Indian farmers and traders to earn better returns through exports. However, disruptions in global supply chains and the rise in freight charges have reduced that opportunity," another exporter said, who wishes not to be quoted.

Wheat production this fiscal year is expected to be a record 120 million tonnes. PTI

The FAO Cereal Price Index averaged 108.6 points in February, up 1.1 points (1.1%) from January, but still 4 points (3.5%) lower than its level a year earlier. World wheat prices rose 1.8% in February, supported by reports of frost and increased winterkill risks in parts of Europe and the US.

"Logistical disruptions in the Russian Federation and continuing tensions in the Black Sea region also contributed to the increase," the FAO said in its report released on 6 March.

"India had the opportunity to tap export markets during the Russia-Ukraine war, but the ban on wheat exports prevented exporters from taking advantage of it," said Bhagwan Meena, a farmer from the Malwa region in Madhya Pradesh.

Echoing the views of farmers and exporters, industry representatives said that traders and processors may remain cautious this season, as escalating tensions in West Asia may disrupt wheat exports to several markets in the region.

"Sentiment among the wheat trade and industry is likely to remain subdued this year, as many incurred losses last season after buying wheat at prices close to minimum support price (MSP) levels, and were unable to recover their carrying costs. As a result, the trade and industry are expected to be more cautious in procurement this season, with many likely to limit purchases and avoid building large inventories to prevent a repeat of last year's losses," said Navneet Chitlangia, president of the Roller Flour Millers' Federation of India.

In response, Indian exporters are likely to redirect supplies to nearby markets where demand remains steady and transportation costs are lower, Chitlangia said.

"Countries such as Bangladesh, Nepal and Sri Lanka are expected to see higher wheat shipments from India as exporters look for stable and accessible markets," Chitlangia added.

Queries sent to the ministry of consumer affairs and food distribution remained unanswered till press time.

dhirendra.kumar@livemint.com

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

CHOPPY WATERS

THE development is a setback for farmers and traders as exports reopened after nearly 4 years

SHIPPING volatility is affecting forward export deals and procurement from farmers

INDUSTRY voices said traders and processors may stay cautious amid West Asia tensions

WORLD wheat prices rose 1.8% in February on frost and winterkill risks in Europe and the US

WTO meet to focus on reforms, farm issues

PTI
feedback@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

WTO reforms, agriculture-related matters, dispute settlement and the e-commerce moratorium are expected to be discussed by trade ministers of 166 countries during the four-day ministerial meeting of the World Trade Organisation in Yaounde, Cameroon, an official said.

Fisheries subsidies, China-led Investment Facilitation for Development (IFD) agreement, e-commerce work programme and moratorium, development and S&DT (special and differential treatment), and level playing field issues are also among the topics that may figure during the 14th ministerial conference of the World Trade Organisation (WTO).

The 14th WTO Ministerial Conference (MC14) will take place from 26 to 29 March, in Yaounde, Cameroon.

The ministerial conference is the highest decision-making body of the Geneva-based World Trade Organization (WTO). It meets every two years. The Indian team will be led by commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal, the official said.

The meeting is important as global trade has been disrupted first by sweeping tariffs imposed by the US and now by the West Asia crisis.

NHAI rushes to secure bitumen as Iran war disrupts supplies

Manas Pimpalkhare & Rituraj Baruah
NEW DELHI

After oil and fertilizer, a new commodity is feeling the heat of the West Asia conflict: bitumen. With India's plan to build nearly 10,000 km of highways in FY27 under threat, the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI) is urgently securing bitumen supplies from state-run oil refiners like Indian Oil Corp. Ltd (IOCL), Bharat Petroleum Corp. Ltd (BPCL), and Hindustan Petroleum Corp. Ltd (HPCL), two people aware of the development said.

"Bitumen prices are revised every 15 days, and in discussions with highway builders, NHAI has said it will coordinate with oil marketing companies IOCL, HPCL, and BPCL to ensure that supplies are not impacted," said one of the people cited above, speaking on the condition of anonymity.

India's annual bitumen requirement is nearly 9 million tonnes. Industry estimates suggest bitumen prices range from ₹40,000-60,000 per tonne in India, depending on quality. Global prices are in the $400-500 per tonne range, roughly equivalent to Indian prices using the current rupee-dollar exchange rate. The ministry of road transport and highways, through NHAI, started discussions with the industry over bitumen supplies because it is a crucial input and India is dependent on West Asian imports, said the second person, also requesting anonymity.

India requires nearly 9 million tonnes of bitumen a year. MINT

Queries emailed to NHAI, road ministry, IOCL, BPCL, HPCL on 6 March remained unanswered.

Experts said India's dependence on bitumen imports is significant, and that a prolonged conflict in West Asia could push India to diversify its sources.

"India imported about 35-36% of its bitumen requirement in FY25, with a significant amount coming from the Middle East (West Asia). Out of the 8.3 million tonnes of bitumen used in India last year, 5.3 million tonnes were made domestically, and the rest was imported," said Prashant Vashisht, senior vice-president and co-group head at ratings agency Icra.

Vashisht said Indian refineries could raise bitumen output, but if the conflict drags on, other import sources such as Singapore or other Southeast Asian nations might be needed.

Other experts said the import dependence could be higher if oil imports are factored in, and that diversifying imports could cover the supply gap but may not reduce prices, which have already begun to increase.

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Global Indian talent in focus as Centre eyes chip autonomy

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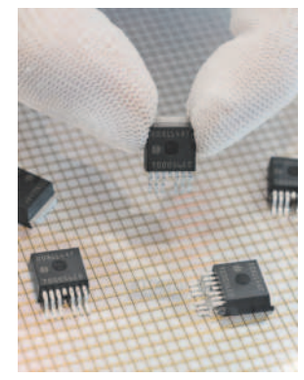
NEW DELHI

India is working towards becoming independent in designing and producing sophisticated microchips under its semiconductor mission, while also attracting Indian professionals with chip-design experience at multinational companies (MNCs), Niti Aayog member Vijay Kumar Saraswat said.

Saraswat, who is also the chancellor of Jawaharlal Nehru University and a former secretary of the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO), said that it is a fact that Indian designers contribute to virtually every chip produced globally.

However, their work is primarily for MNCs, and they are often limited to designing subsystems or specific components rather than complete system designs.

"As a result, while India has a large number of designers in this sector, there are very few who can do ab initio design of a complete system. There is an effort being made today that we will build this capability using those designers who have worked for MNCs so that India becomes a fully independent chip designer. That effort is being made under the semiconductor mission," Saraswat said in an interview with *Mint*.



The push comes when tech is increasingly shaping industrial and military power. AFP

Saraswat also said that specific features and the incentive structure under the second phase of the India Semiconductor Mission announced in Union budget 2026 are being worked out.

Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman announced the second phase of the mission in her budget speech to scale up India's capabilities in equipment, materials, design, intellectual property rights and to fortify the supply chain.

In the budget for 2026-27, the Centre announced a second tranche of sops under the mission, five years after rolling out the first ₹76,000-crore programme.

India will also strive to explore and produce select critical minerals found domestically, to guard against the risk of supply denial by other countries, Saraswat said. India's push to build domestic capabilities in semiconductors and critical minerals, which are vital for IT, clean energy and defence sectors, comes at a time tech is increasingly shaping industrial and military power in a de-globalising world.

Export curbs on certain classes of advanced semiconductors had been a pain point in US-China relations in the past.

For an extended version of the story, go to livemint.com

India weighs tighter rules on nicotine lozenge sales

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NEW DELHI

India plans to tighten rules governing the sale of nicotine lozenges, moving them from general store counters to regulated pharmacy shelves to curb easy access among minors and non-smokers.

The move would remove 2 mg nicotine lozenges from the exemption under Schedule K of the Drugs Rules, 1945, which currently allows certain nicotine replacement therapy (NRT) products to be sold without a drug sale licence. Thus, retailers would need a formal licence to sell nicotine lozenges, according to two officials and documents seen by *Mint*.

The proposal follows recommendations by the Drugs Technical Advisory Board (DTAB) at a meeting held in February. The board also called for a strict ban on sales to minors and closer monitoring of online platforms to prevent easy access. Queries sent to the health ministry remained unanswered till press time.

In India, NRT products including nicotine gums and lozenges are regulated as drugs under the Drugs and Cosmetics Act as they are used to reduce tobacco dependence. However, under a special exemption in Schedule K, nicotine gums and lozenges containing 2 mg of nicotine can be sold without a drug sale licence.

The advisory board called for strict ban on sales to minors, tighter online monitoring. MINT

According to the meeting minutes reviewed by *Mint*, the board was also informed about recommendations from the Indian Council of Medical Research and the Tobacco Control Division. After deliberation, DTAB recommended amending entry 33 of Schedule K so that the exemption applies only to unflavoured 2 mg nicotine gums, and not to any other NRT products.

The board also recommended that sales to minors be prohibited, online access closely monitored, and post-marketing surveillance be conducted to track adverse effects.

"Further, DTAB recommended that nicotine lozenges 2 mg shall be excluded from Schedule K exemptions," the document added.

"The board has recommended narrowing these exemptions significantly. Under the new plan only unflavoured 2 mg nicotine gums will continue to be exempt from a sale license. All 2 mg nicotine lozenges will now require a formal drug sale license. This move effectively pulls lozenges, which often come in attractive flavours, off general store shelves and places them behind the pharmacy counter," said one of the two officials cited above.

Q A with mint

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Sincerely,
— Ravi Krishnan
Editor-in-Chief

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First published in February 2007 to serve as an unbiased and clear-minded chronicler of the Indian Dream.

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Zepto plans updated IPO filing by April-end

Firm's proposed valuation under scrutiny as funds review unit economics

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Investors are assessing unit economics—including order values, delivery costs and retention—even as outreach to global institutional investors is yet to begin. ISTOCKPHOTO

Quick-commerce operator Zepto Ltd is targeting a late April deadline for filing updated documents for an initial public offering (IPO) with India's market regulator, even as it faces valuation concerns, said three people aware of the matter.

Zepto's December 2025 confidential filing is likely to be cleared in another four weeks, one of the people quoted earlier said–all three spoke on the condition of anonymity. Following the clearance, Zepto plans to file its updated draft red herring prospectus with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) before the end of April, this person added.

An updated prospectus is a public disclosure of the share sale details to investors after confidential filings. These include financial metrics, risk factors, and operational data.

Zepto did not respond to queries emailed on 6 March.

Zepto's management has initiated preliminary talks with domestic mutual funds, the second person said.

IPO-bound companies use these interactions to gauge domestic institutional interest and secure anchor participation for their upcoming issue. Domestic institutional investors often provide baseline stability for large-scale public offerings in the Indian market, absorbing significant portions of the qualified institutional buyer (QIB) quota.

Outreach to international institutional investors has not yet commenced, the second person added. Zepto plans to formally tap global investors only after the updated offer document is filed and the regulatory review process advances, the person said.

However, the Aadit Palicha-led company's valuation target for a public share sale has also come under review, the third person told *Mint*.

Zepto was valued at $7 billion in its $450 million private capital raise, led by the California Public Employees' Retirement System, in October 2025.

Current conversations indicate that the IPO valuation can be reduced by 15-20% from that figure, the third person said. This adjustment establishes a base valuation range of $5.6 billion to $5.95 billion for the public market debut.

The *Economic Times* had reported in December that the the company's offer was likely to be worth $1.3 billion. A confidential filing allows companies to revise the offer size.

The IPO timeline and valuations could change going ahead, depending on market conditions and investor response, all three people quoted earlier said.

"There have been measurable changes in the dynamics of the quick commerce sector over the last few months," the chief investment officer at a domestic mutual fund told *Mint*, speaking on the condition of anonymity.

"Competing firms such as Eternal Ltd's Blinkit, Swiggy Ltd's Instamart and newer entrants like Amazon and Flipkart are already crowding the space," the person said. "Asset managers are obviously reviewing unit economics data, including average order values, delivery costs per order, and customer retention rates, to determine appropriate entry multiples."

In fiscal 2025, Zepto's top line jumped 129% year-on-year to ₹9,669 crore, but net loss widened nearly three times to ₹3,367 crore.

If the share sale goes through, it will mark one of the shortest journeys from launch to listing in India's consumer internet market.

Founded by Palicha and Kaivalya Vohra in 2021, Zepto has raised large external rounds of funding as it spent aggressively to build its market share against Blinkit and Instamart.

VALUATION RESET

ZEPTO'S December 2025 confidential filing may receive regulatory clearance within four weeks

IT'S in preliminary talks with domestic mutual funds to gauge anchor investor interest

THE company's IPO valuation may be cut by 15-20% from its previous $7-billion valuation

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2026 Trends: Why is the traditional omnichannel model no longer sufficient for customer engagement?

The traditional omnichannel model which relies on SMS, emails, and phone calls has fractured under the weight of rising spam and scam anxiety. As lenders add more channels, customer trust paradoxically collapses. This has triggered a "Signal-to-Noise" crisis: with 70% of calls now ignored due to fraud fears, financial institutions are effectively "broadcasting in the dark," leading to unnecessary delinquencies.

Furthermore, omnichannel expansion relies on fragmented third-party vendors (like SMS gateways and dialers). This creates a "Third-Party Data Trap," spreading customer data across external servers and drastically increasing the surface area for PII breaches.

Ultimately, these legacy channels have become "dumb pipes" incapable of executing the granular, real-time strategies demanded by modern risk analytics.

What is the alternative to chasing customers across fragmented channels?

The alternative is shifting from "probabilistic outreach" to an infrastructure that is Sovereign, Deterministic, and Embedded. Instead of chasing phone numbers that frequently change, institutions must embed a Digital Operating System like the TrueDigi SDK directly into their existing mobile banking apps.

By integrating the TrueDigi SDK:

- The app becomes an **active engagement engine,** not just a utility.
- Communication moves off **public telecom rails** into the bank's secure environment.
- Institutions achieve **100% Right Party Contact (RPC)** through device-level targeting.
- Third-party aggregators are eliminated.
- Engagement operates on a **Zero-PII architecture,** ensuring no sensitive data leaves the bank's firewall.

How does this model support real-time intelligence while remaining compliant and scalable?

This embedded model fuses speed with safety through a "Governance-First" architecture, balancing real-time intelligence and compliance via two primary mechanisms:

1. **Compliance as Code:** The platform captures bi-directional behavioural telemetry to trigger AI-driven, hyper-personalized interventions instantly. To do this safely, it utilizes an Automated Governance Hub where all communication formats and Digital Legal Notices are pre-approved and locked. This ensures every algorithmic decision and real-time intervention is legally defensible without human approval bottlenecks.
2. **The "Zero-PII" Scaling Model:** Traditional systems struggle to scale securely because they handle massive amounts of sensitive data. TrueDigi operates entirely on anonymized IDs. It processes deep behavioural intelligence for millions of customers without ever seeing a Name, National ID, or Phone Number. Coupled with localized, sovereign infrastructure, this allows banks to scale their predictive intelligence infinitely without increasing their privacy risk.

The shift is architectural:

- From **fragmented outreach** to **embedded digital rails**
- From **probability** to **certainty**
- From **chasing customers** to **building infrastructure**

For more information on Dun & Bradstreet Big Shifts, Bold Ideas: Trends Shaping India's Financial Future 2026
Contact: 022 4941 6666 | Email: india@dnb.com

Bertelsmann sees rural India as its big investment frontier

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Pankaj Makkar, managing director, Bertelsmann India Investments. MINT

Venture capital firm Bertelsmann India Investments (BII) is doubling down on startups targeting the rural markets, according to a senior executive at the firm.

"Thesis is clear—the investments we make either have to help villages make money or help them spend money," Pankaj Makkar, managing director at BII, told *Mint*.

For the early growth-stage corporate venture fund, there is a distinction between what venture capitalists call 'Bharat' and rural India. While the term is often used broadly, it does not fully capture the fundamental issues facing rural India. "The problem statement in villages isn't to outbid competitors through marketing. It's creating distribution and investing in infrastructure."

Rural India as a market is largely untapped, driven primarily by a lack of infrastructure and low transaction value. There have, however, been some successes in the form of business-to-business players like Ninjacart, a supply chain platform connecting farmers to retailers; Peak XV-backed full stack agri-tech platform DeHaat; and grain storage startup Arya.ag, which raised $80 million in a Series D round led by GEF Capital Partners in January this year.

BII has three investments in the segment: AgroStar, CureBay and Rozana. Recently, BII doubled down on investment in Rozana, leading its ₹290 crore (around $32 million) Series B round, which saw participation from Fireside Ventures, Spark Growth Ventures, FE Securities, the Bikaji family office and other family offices. Rozana had previously raised $22.5 million in its Series A round led by BII in 2024.

Prior to the Rozana investment, the Indian venture arm of Bertelsmann led AgroStar's $27 million Series C round in 2019. It participated in subsequent funding rounds as well.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

MINT MEDIA MARKETING INITIATIVE

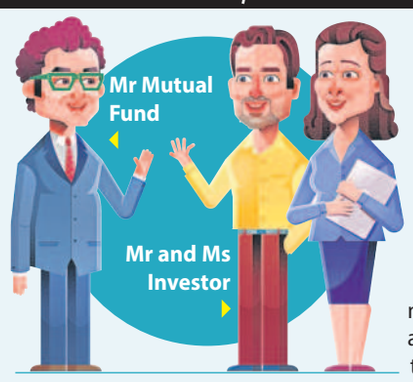
Her money, her control, her future

smarTomorrows by CANARA ROBECO Mutual Fund
An Investor education and awareness initiative

In India, financial decisions are still largely managed by men, fathers, husbands, or other family members. There is nothing inherently wrong with this shared approach. However, life is unpredictable. In uncertain situations, such as the loss of the primary decision-maker, women may suddenly need to take charge of finances. Without preparation, this transition can be overwhelming and risky.

A woman's financial journey is rarely linear. Unlike men, women's life timelines often include career breaks, whether due to pregnancy, childcare or personal choices. Income patterns may pause or fluctuate, but financial responsibilities never do. This makes financial awareness not just important, but essential.

Adding to this challenge is the age of mis-selling and misinformation. A lack of awareness about financial products increases the chances of being sold unsuitable investments, this can happen to anyone. Hence, educating oneself about efficient and transparent ways of managing money becomes a form of financial self-defence.



Ms Investor: Why can't I just invest in stocks directly if I want higher returns?

Mr Mutual Fund: Stocks require active management, constant tracking, and emotional discipline. You won't always get the stock selection right. You cannot time the market. Markets are volatile, hence the diversification of investments is important.

Mutual funds address these challenges effectively. They are managed by experienced professionals backed by research teams and risk frameworks. More importantly, mutual funds operate in a highly regulated ecosystem, offering diversification across multiple stocks, sectors, and even asset classes, something difficult to achieve individually.

To understand this better, the key differences between investments directly made by the investors and the ones routed through mutual funds are given in the box.

Ms Investor: I cannot invest a large sum of money in mutual funds right now.

Mr Mutual Fund: That's where Systematic Investment Plans (SIPs) help. For instance, you can choose to invest either a lump sum or in instalments of regular contributions of fixed sums like a recurring deposit in a bank. This method of investing in instalments is referred to as a Systematic Investment Plan (SIP). A SIP allows you to invest a fixed sum of money, at regular intervals decided by you, in a mutual fund scheme. So, you're consistently investing, regardless of market fluctuations. SIPs put your investments on auto-pilot. You invest a fixed amount regularly while professionals handle the asset allocation and market-cap exposure.

SIPs can be a powerful way of investing, for women. They continue seamlessly during career breaks, encourage discipline, and remove the stress of market timing. Compounding works quietly in their favour over time.

Empowering women financially is not about replacing shared decision-making, it's about readiness. By understanding mutual funds and using SIPs wisely, women can stay prepared for life's uncertainties, and build long-term financial confidence and independence.

Aspect	Direct Investments	Mutual Funds
Diversification	Investor is responsible (higher concentration risk)	Portfolios comprise a basket of securities diversified across sectors/asset classes
Investment Instrument	Equity, debt and other assets to be invested in separately	Equity, debt, and other assets may form a part of one fund
Control	Investor has full control of investment decisions	Fund managers have the control of investment decisions for mutual funds
Management	Self-managed by the investor	Managed by professionals

Mutual Fund investments are subject to market risks, read all scheme related documents carefully.

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Have fun with facts on Sundays

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HT TWTW
THE WEEK THAT WAS
A quiz on the week's development.

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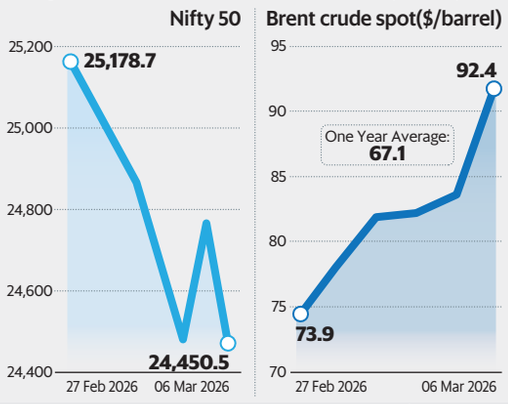
	S&P BSE Sensex	Nifty 50	Nifty 500	Nifty Next 50	Nifty 100	S&P BSE Mid-cap	S&P BSE Small Cap
CLOSE	78918.88	24450.45	22481.3	67476.65	25134.9	15508.72	6104.32
1-WEEK CHANGE (%)	-2.91	-2.89	-2.96	-3.21	-2.94	-3.12	-3.07
1-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-5.58	-4.84	-4.07	-2.29	-4.42	-3.47	-3.38
3-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-7.93	-6.63	-5.68	-1.79	-5.85	-5.34	-8.01
6-MONTH CHANGE (%)	-2.22	-1.17	-1.52	0.58	-0.88	-2.02	-9.72
1-YEAR CHANGE (%)	6.16	8.45	9.95	12.25	9.10	11.78	-2.34

War worry

Investors aren't buying the dip, raising chances of the Nifty falling to as low as 23,800 unless tensions abate, per analysts.



Source: Bloomberg

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MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT

Bulls not buying the dip this time as caution rules

FROM PAGE 1

Simply put, this measure shows that bullish investors and traders are carrying forward fewer long positions despite the market falling nearly 3% since the war began.

The value of the marketwide calls exceeded that of marketwide puts by ₹2.71 trillion on Friday, down from ₹4.34 trillion a week ago before the war began, said Rohit Srivastava, founder of analytics firm IndiaCharts.

"This decline clearly indicates that bulls are not buying the dip, in turn reflecting the lingering uncertainty among investors amid the escalation of the West Asia conflict," said Srivastava.

He added that the figure of ₹2.71 trillion worth of excess calls over puts was close to the historic mean of ₹2.5-2.6 trillion, an "anomaly" after the recent market fall. Srivastava cited the rebound a day after the call value exceeded the put value by a record ₹5.4 trillion a day before the Indo-US interim trade deal news on 2 February. The deal drove the market up 4.8% from 24,825.4 on 1 February through a high of 26,009.4 on 11 February.

Again, on 13 February, after the value of calls over puts hit ₹5.19 trillion, the Nifty bounced 1.6% from a close of 25471 to a high of 25,885.3 on 19 February, cites IndiaCharts.

However, in the current fall, there has been no such rise in call value, indicating that investors and traders alike remain unsure, said Kruti Shah, quant analyst at Equirus.

"In fact, the near 3% fall in markets last Friday to this one (24,450.45 on this Friday) has broken the crucial market support of 24,600, increasing the probability of a further 3% fall to the next critical support zone of 23,800-24,000, unless odds of a ceasefire shorten," said Shah.

Those transacting in marketwide call and put options include retail/HNI, domestic and foreign institutional investors and proprietary traders, NSE data showed.

Investors, traders are carrying fewer long positions despite the market falling 3% since the war began

"Net FPI buying witnessed in February has reversed due to the Middle East conflict," notes VK Vijayakumar, chief investment strategist, Geojit Investments Ltd. FPIs are unlikely to return to the market as buyers until there is some clarity on the outcome of the conflict and decline in the price of crude, he added.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Middle East turmoil may hit L&T

Shubham Dilawari
feedback@livemint.com

Larsen & Toubro Ltd's (L&T) shares have fallen nearly 8% over the past week in reaction to the conflict in the Middle East after Iran faced a joint attack by the US and Israel. The engineering company's significant exposure to the region in terms of orders and revenues is bad news for its investors. There are worries about deferment or cancellation of new orders and execution delays in ongoing projects amid disruptions to shipping routes.

Over a decade ago, domestic projects had dominated L&T's business, but the picture is different now. As on 31 December, 49% of its ₹7.33 trillion order book came from international markets, and India contributed the rest. The Middle East accounts for 75.5% of the international order book. For the nine months ended December (9MFY26), the Middle East contributed 33% of the ₹3.45 trillion order inflow and 34% of its ₹2 trillion consolidated revenues.

L&T's order prospects pipeline for the March quarter (Q4FY26) stands at ₹5.92 trillion, including ₹1.26 trillion for the Hydrocarbon segment. The overseas market is expected to contribute a large part of this pipeline. "Given the ongoing hostilities, we see about 10% impact on the FY26 order inflow, basis the order prospect pipeline," said Emkay Global Financial Services in a report on 4 March. "For L&T, 12,000-15,000 workers are presently working in the Middle East region. While it is difficult to assess the current situation, we estimate that L&T's core earnings will be negatively impacted by 11-12% for FY27E/28E, assuming a three-month execution delay and low order inflow mainly in the hydrocarbon segment," it added.

L&T has already been struggling with weak execution in recent quarters despite robust orders. The management had reiterated its FY26 revenue growth guidance of 15% while announcing Q3 results, anticipating "the customary ramp-up in project execution during Q4." L&T's projects & manufacturing Ebitda margin stood at 7.9% for 9MFY26 against its target of 8.5% for the full year FY26.

A potential threat to the margin persists. "A boom in the real estate segment in the UAE has resulted in cushioning the impact of Chinese competition," said JM Financial Institutional Securities. "In the event real estate slows down due to increased security concerns in the region, competitive intensity may increase, which can have margin repercussions."

Over time, rising contributions from higher-margin segments such as hi-tech manufacturing (including defence systems, aerospace engineering and precision equipment) can support margin expansion. Hi-tech manufacturing's order book of ₹37,900 crore as on 31 December reflects growing demand for advanced engineering capabilities. While hi-tech manufacturing contributed just about 5% of L&T's Q3FY26 revenue, there is potential for faster growth in future.

For now, meaningful upsides in the stock, which hit a 52-week high of ₹4,440 on 24 February, could be limited amid the conflict and looming concerns on artificial intelligence (AI) hurting the valuation of its IT businesses. "With a constantly changing scenario in the Middle East impacting core EPC business and increasing risks for IT business from AI-led disruption, LT is turning more into a 'moving parts' thesis from a 'sum-of-the-parts' thesis," says Motilal Oswal Financial Services. The broking firm has adjusted its core business valuations to bake in the current volatile environment, arriving at a revised two-year forward target price of ₹4,400 (versus ₹4,600 earlier).

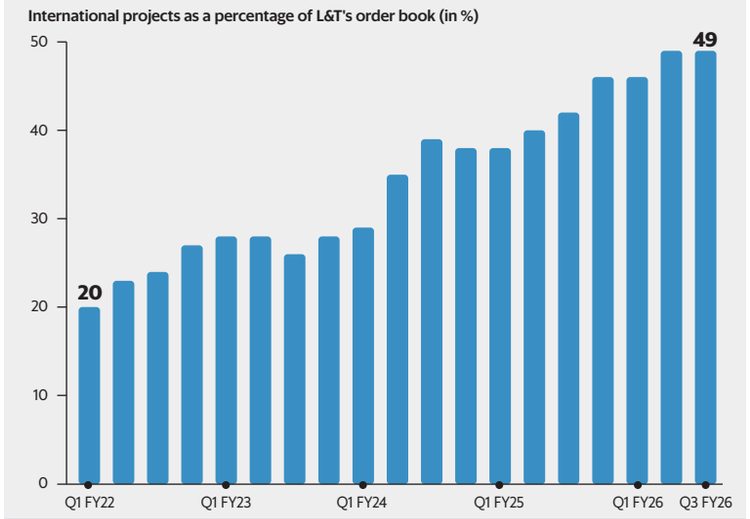
ON SHAKY GROUND

L&T has been struggling with weak execution in recent quarters despite robust orders

HIGHER share of segments such as hi-tech manufacturing may lift margins over time

Foreign heft

Larsen & Toubro's international order book has been rising over the past few years.



Source: Company, Motilal Oswal Financial Services

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GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

Mark to Market writers do not hold positions in the companies discussed here unless otherwise informed

Nearly every third investor is now a woman, small-town India leads

Mayur Bhalerao & Niti Kiran
MUMBAI

The Indian stock market is morphing from a solo act into a duet as women rapidly expand their footprint in capital markets. According to the latest data from the National Stock Exchange (as of January 31), nearly 25% of individual investors in India is now a woman—a notable increase from 22.5% in FY23.

Financial experts attribute this trend to deeper structural changes in Indian society. "As more women earn and manage their own income, the focus is gradually moving beyond traditional savings avenues toward market-linked investments that offer long-term growth potential," said Sneha Poddar, VP-research, wealth management at Motilal Oswal Financial Services Ltd.

Rajesh Palviya, head of research at Axis Securities highlighted the role of technology, noting that the rapid digitisation of financial services has lowered entry barriers.

Beyond the financial hubs

But from where is all this money flowing in? Surprisingly, these are not the traditional financial hubs but smaller states and the north-east.

Goa currently has the highest female investor participation rate, at 33.2% in the fiscal year so far, up from a 30.2% three years ago. It is followed closely by Mizoram (32.5%), Chandigarh (32.4%), Sikkim (31.4%) and Delhi (31%). These regions are significantly outperforming the national average, suggesting a more balanced gender approach to wealth creation.

In FY23 only Assam and Chandigarh were in the 30% club, with women investors accounting for 30.9% and 30.6% of their investor bases, respectively. However, Assam slipped to 29.5% in FY26.

Sanaa Zia Khan, director at Centricity Overseas Financial Distribution Pvt Ltd, said, "Higher female investor participation in smaller states may reflect a mix of structural and demographic factors. Many of these regions have relatively higher literacy levels and a growing concentration of wealth in Tier-2 cities and smaller urban centres." She added, "As incomes rise, households are shifting from traditional savings to financial assets. Greater awareness campaigns and first-time-investor-friendly platforms have also made investing more accessible."

Coming to the next milestone, more than half of Indian states now have a female-investor share that exceeds the national average of nearly 25%. A little over a quarter of these states—including Goa, Mizoram and Delhi—outpace the national average by more than six percentage points (pps).

Nine states and Union Territories, including financial hubs of Maharashtra and Gujarat, sit 3-5 pps above the average.

Another five states including as Punjab and Haryana maintain a steady lead of up to 3 pps above the national average. However, Lakshadweep and Bihar trail by significant margin, with lowest female participation rates of 15.9% and 16.4%, respectively.

Steady gains all over

Despite this, the underlying momentum is undeniably positive as the needle is moving in the right direction nearly everywhere. Even in regions with historically lower participation, such as Bihar and Jammu and Kashmir, the numbers have risen from 13.8% to over 16% between FY23 and FY26.

Maharashtra, a massive market, has seen its female share grow from 25.6% to 28.9% since FY23. Gujarat follows a similar path of steady inclusion, touching 28.3% in the current fiscal year so far.

Leading the charge once again are smaller and north-eastern states such as Sikkim and Arunachal Pradesh, with women's share jumping over 500 basis points during this period.

The road ahead

The next phase of growth for women in the markets will depend less on mere access and more on building sustained confidence and engagement. Poddar said, "The next phase of growth will likely depend on confidence, engagement, and the broader investment ecosystem." She observed that many first-time women investors tend to approach markets with a longer-term perspective and a focus on financial stability. She suggested that financial institutions build on this by shifting the narrative toward goal-based investing frameworks, connecting equities with milestones such as retirement planning and financial independence.

"With the intensification of digital usage and the spread of financial education in smaller cities, women's engagement with capital markets is expected to speed up and create a more diverse and resilient retail investor base," said Anupama Sharma, co-business head, 360 ONE Wealth.

Palviya said he remained optimistic about the trajectory. "Looking ahead, we anticipate that the participation of women investors will continue to accelerate. As digital access expands, financial education improves, and more women enter the formal workforce, their presence in capital markets is expected to grow. Ultimately, this trend will not only broaden the investor base but also enhance the ongoing financialisation of household savings in India," he said.

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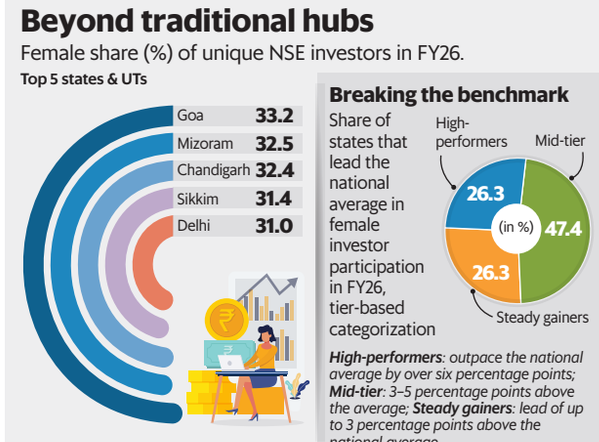
Beyond traditional hubs

Female share (%) of unique NSE investors in FY26.



Data for FY26 is as of 31 January 2026.

Source: National Stock Exchange, Mint analysis

mint

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

'India fits the profile as investors look for stability in a volatile world'

Dipti Sharma
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MUMBAI

INTERVIEW

At a time when uncertainty often pushes investors to the sidelines, Swati Khemani, founder and chief executive officer of Carnelian Asset Management and Advisors, has been closely engaging with clients amid heightened market volatility.

She believes the next big shift could come from global capital flows. If money exits developed markets, especially as US interest rates ease, some may flow into long-term growth markets like India.

"In a volatile world, investors look for economies that offer stability and growth, and India fits that profile."

Edited excerpts:

How have your discussions with investors evolved over time—say, from five months ago to now—given the heightened volatility and rapid developments?

Two things have changed. First, client conversations have matured over time. Investors today are far more informed, largely because of social media and easy access to information. Earlier, any geopolitical event could trigger panic—markets would fall sharply, and investors would rush to redeem. Today, that reaction is far less common. In fact, even during recent volatility, we haven't seen panic calls or redemptions like we would have pre-covid. Conversations are now more structured. People want to understand where markets are headed rather than reacting emotionally to every event.

The second change is in investor behaviour. After covid, many believed they could manage money themselves because returns were strong. But the volatility over the last couple of years has reminded people that markets aren't a one-way journey. Now we are again seeing investors come back for professional advice, whether through mutual funds or PMS, because managing money consistently isn't as easy as it seems.

And specifically on the US-Iran conflict, do you see it turning into a prolonged episode or something that could ease relatively soon?

As for the US-Iran situation, it's very hard to predict how long it may last. It could ease eventually, especially given the leadership uncertainty, but conflicts today are far more complex. Conflicts like Russia-Ukraine show how issues can drag on and flare up depending on global power interests. In West Asia, too, tensions have been building since the Israel-Gaza conflict in October. There are also strong religious sentiments involved, so it's not simply about one leader being removed and the situation ending. These conflicts run deeper than that.

At the same time, we must remember that there were conversations and warnings before the escalation, so countries would have also considered possible contingencies.

Could it impact investor sentiment in India?

The immediate impact on India may not be very significant. A lot of credit goes to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, as over the last 10 years, India has handled many delicate situations diplomatically. The government has generally taken a balanced and responsible approach. For instance, on tariffs last year, it would have been easy to give in, but India held its ground and eventually negotiated a better outcome. So I believe the leadership understands these dynamics well, and that reduces the risk of any direct fallout for India.

More importantly, India's structural story remains strong. This is something we've been discussing with clients as well. Despite the current events, fundamentals haven't changed. Corporate earnings, especially from the December quarter, were broadly healthy. Autos are improving, the capex cycle is picking up, and policy steps like GST (goods and services tax) cuts will start showing benefits over the next three to six months. Any policy move takes time—three, six or even nine months—to reflect in the economy.

Whether you look at fiscal health, corporate balance sheets or household leverage, things are far more stable than before. Regulatory changes and cleaner systems have also reduced risks, such as excessive leverage and sudden margin funding crises. So even if global events cause temporary disruptions, they don't derail the broader trajectory.

...Even on oil, which is the biggest concern if the Strait of Hormuz were disrupted, India has diversified its sourcing. As seen during the Russia-Ukraine conflict, the country has managed energy supplies pragmatically. So overall, India is far better positioned to absorb such shocks.

Do you think capital could start gravitating back toward India now?

In fact, if global capital starts moving out of developed markets, especially once US interest rates begin to fall, some of that money could flow into stable, long-term growth markets like India. In a volatile world, investors look for economies that offer stability and growth, and India fits that profile.

At this point, there's no need to make any significant shifts in portfolios despite these global disturbances.

So in times like these, what are the key factors you usually monitor?

Staying focused on domestically driven businesses and import substitution also serves as a natural hedge against these disruptions.

As long-term investors, we have to be mindful of what a business model depends on. For example, if we invest in aviation, we must remember that oil is a very big variable. And in today's environment, disruptions can easily push oil prices off track. That's why we generally avoid such stories unless there is a clear short-term opportunity based on valuations or positioning.

Our portfolios typically hold about 25–30 stocks. We prefer a focused approach rather than excessive diversification. The idea is to do deep homework and invest in businesses with long-term potential, while stress-testing key variables that could impact them.

In a market as large as ours, even within the top 500 companies, it's not difficult to find 25–30 strong businesses that fit this approach.

Do you also have a big exposure to defence stocks?

No, as much as we'd love to, we have a very small exposure to defence.

It fits the bill, right? With the import-substitution and domestic themes.

It absolutely fits the bill. But the challenge has always been that there are very few listed defence players. And over the last two–three years, despite all the excitement around defence, we haven't really seen numbers that justify the valuations.

For an extended version, visit livemint.om

> India's structural story remains strong...despite the current events, fundamentals haven't changed.
>
> **Swati Khemani**
> founder and CEO of Carnelian Asset Management and Advisors

Rising demand may aid Tata Power to restart Mundra unit

The 4,000-MW thermal power plant is shut since last July due to disputes with client states

Nehal Chaliawala
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MUMBAI

Talks with Gujarat, other states on a supplementary power purchase agreement are progressing, says CEO Praveer Sinha.. MINT

Tata Power's idled 4,000-megawatt Mundra thermal power plant in Gujarat could restart soon, likely before the end of March, managing director and chief executive Praveer Sinha said, even as the company has repeatedly missed its own timelines to bring the plant back into operation.

"Mundra is starting soon, it is just a matter of time," Sinha told *Mint* on the sidelines of a press conference on Friday after announcing its partnership with Salesforce. A supplementary power purchase agreement (SPPA) with Gujarat and other client states should happen "very quickly," he said, declining to elaborate further.

The ultra mega power project in the coastal town is closed since July 2025 amid disagreements with client states—Gujarat, Rajasthan, Punjab, Maharashtra and Haryana—over the pass through of high cost of Indonesian coal.

Analysts at brokerage IIFL said a combination of rising power demand ahead of summer and the possibility of higher fuel prices due to the war in West Asia could strengthen Tata Power's negotiating position this time. Historically, sharp rallies in natural gas prices, such as the one seen currently, have also pushed coal prices higher as fuel substitution plays out in electricity markets, they said.

Asia spot liquefied natural gas price more than doubled compared to last week and reached the highest level in over three years after a production halt by Qatar, which provides 20% of global LNG supply, has triggered a scramble for gas, according to a *Reuters* report dated 6 March.

Average LNG price for April delivery into north-east Asia was estimated at $22.50 per million British thermal units (mmBtu), the highest since mid-January 2023 and over double the price of $10.40/mmBtu in the previous week, the report said, citing experts.

"Sustained rise in coal prices, along with uncertainty around LNG supply and elevated summer power demand, can catalyse a resolution at Mundra," IIFL analysts said in a 3 March report.

Higher global coal prices could benefit Tata Power in two ways, the analysts said. The company would gain directly through its 30% stake in an Indonesian coal mine. Every $20 increase in the per-tonne price of Indonesian coal could add about 10% to Tata Power's consolidated earnings, the IIFL analysts estimate. The coal typically sells at $70-80 per tonne.

Higher coal prices could also accelerate a resolution for the Mundra plant itself. The shutdown cost the company about ₹1,000 crore in lost profits during the first nine months of FY26, the analysts estimated.

Whether Tata Power manages to lock in a deal for the Mundra plant will have a significant bearing on its share price, which trades at 10x its 12-month forward Ebitda, a discount to its long-term median of 11x. The scrip closed at ₹375.45 on the BSE on Friday, up 6% since the Mundra plant was shut.

In an investor call on 4 February, Sinha said it reached an agreement with Gujarat on all the issues of the SPPA barring one. He did not disclose what it was, but said the firm hoped to resolve it in 2-3 weeks. "On a similar basis, we will parallelly start discussing with other states so that we are in a position to start operation of the plant, maybe by the end of this month." It was the third resumption guidance by the company that did not come to pass.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

POWER REVIVAL

TATA Power could benefit from rising coal prices via its 30% stake in a coal mine in Indonesia

THE shutdown cost the company about ₹1,000 crore in lost profits in the first nine months of FY26

A resolution at the Mundra facility may significantly influence Tata Power's share price

HIGHER gas prices can push up coal demand and prices as power producers switch fuels

'Bold Care betting on brand buzz over performance ads'

Soumya Gupta
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MUMBAI

INTERVIEW

Sexual wellness brand Bold Care first went viral in 2024 with a saas-bahu style soap opera ad starring actor (and investor) Ranveer Singh and adult entertainment star Johnny Sins, promoting its condoms and other products. Since then, it rolled out campaigns featuring celebrities and influencers known for speaking their mind—sometimes courting controversy. In an interview, co-founder and chief executive Rajat Jadhav says the aim is to reduce long-term dependence on expensive performance marketing and focus more on brand awareness. *Edited excerpts:*

Your Johnny Sins ad broke the internet. How are you recreating that reach?

We have been doing a number of campaigns with (stand-up comedian) Samay (Raina) for the last year or so. There was one with him and Raj Shamani and one with him and (director) Anurag Kashyap. We did a simple one where we filled Samay's car with condoms. We wanted to do a simple ad. That simple creative alone got us 55 million impressions and over 1.5 million likes. We are also running an outdoor ad campaign. We wanted to have some billboards go live and turn it into a game, getting online users to create the best content on finding them.

That seems like a shift from how D2C brands market?

What we do in marketing, especially for such campaigns, is we are no longer focused on performance marketing. We don't want to do these cookie-cutter campaigns with a standard CTA (call to action) and a set format. The amount of work we have done in the last year and half allows us to focus on brand awareness instead.

Creatives like the one with Samay's car work because it is not the first thing we did as a brand. People will be confused otherwise. But since we keep doing creative campaigns like this again and again, people expect it. See the comments (of our social media posts) people are discussing how this is the way Bold Care does marketing. A lot of it is championed by Rahul (Krishnan), my co-founder.

But performance marketing is measurable. Isn't it harder to track returns on investment in brand campaigns?

We have one of the best RoAS [return on ad spends] for any D2C brand out there. We have also been working to achieve profitability over the last year and a half.

So, our organic revenues are very high, and our retention and conversion rates are the best in the category. We have the second-highest market share [in sexual wellness], and we have taken some of Durex's market share as well.

These campaigns don't give me revenue optics right on the day. But in the last 30-plus quarters, we have seen steady growth, and we are spending significantly less on marketing. Online sexual health is not like BPC [beauty and personal care]. We have done a lot of work in category creation, so it is no longer about the numbers, but about getting the audience to engage.

How do you balance using Ranveer Singh with other celebrities in your ads?

Ranveer and team worked closely with us on branding and marketing on our first campaign. But we have to create a pyramid where we are not just leaning on Ranveer Singh only. We lean on our good work with Anurag Kashyap and Samay Raina. In fact, we discuss our marketing campaign ideas with Ranveer and Samay as well. They have both been really good for our brand. Ranveer is high-energy, and Samay fits our humour-first marketing.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

> In the last 30-plus quarters, we saw steady growth, and we are spending significantly less on marketing
>
> **Rajat Jadhav**
> Co-founder and CEO
> Bold Care

BRIHANMUMBAI MUNICIPAL CORPORATION
Public Health Department
No. HO/26537/AC Dt.06.03.2026
e-Tender Notice

The Commissioner of the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) invites e-Tender in Packer 'A', 'B', & 'C' system for the following work as stated below.

Department	:	Public Health Department
Bid No	:	2026_MCGM_1284470
Subject	:	Procurement of Comprehensive Maintenance Contract (CMC) for Tablet under Public Health Department
Tender Date	:	From: 09.03.2026 at 11:00 hrs To : 16.03.2026 upto 16:00 hrs
Website	:	http://www.mahtender.gov.in http://www.portal.mcgm.gov.in (For advertisement Only)
Contact Officer		
a) Name	:	Dr. Neelam Kadam Dy. Executive Health Officer (O-II)
b) Telephone No.	:	022-24134560 Ext.-243
c) e-mail id	:	aoac01.phd@mcgm.gov.in

PRO/3213/ADV/2025-26

Sd/-
Dr. Daksha Shah
Executive Health Officer
(Public Health Department)

Keep the terraces clean, remove odd articles/junk/scrap.

CENTRAL RAILWAY
SOLAPUR DIVISION
E-PROCUREMENT

Divisional Store Office Central Railway, Solapur for and on Behalf of President of India invites online e-tenders on Railway's e-procurement website **www.ireps.gov.in** from the capable, reputed firms/ Contractors for the following works. **01 Tender No:-** 96265076, **02 Description:-** Jointless grooved Copper Contact Wire, 107Sq.mm made out of continuous cast copper wire rods as per RDSO Specification No. TI/SPC/OHE/CW/0971 or latest. **03 Quantity:-** 17.5 KM, **04 Earnest Money (INR):-** Rs.311690.00, **Date & Time of Closing of Tender on www.ireps.gov.in:-** 30-03-2026 after 11:30., The prospective tenderers are advised to revisit the website frequently before the date of closing of tender to note any changes/corrigenda issued for this tender. Website: **www.ireps.gov.in.**

15 Sr.DMM/Solapur

Travel safely, Avoid footboard travelling

SYAMA PRASAD MOOKERJEE PORT, KOLKATA
(A Statutory Body under the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, Government of India)
Regd. Office: 15, Strand Rd, Fairley Place, B.B.D. Bagh, Kolkata, West Bengal, 700001

Tender No.: SDM-PE/T/29/2025-2026

Design, Engineering, Supply, Installation, Testing & Commissioning for the work of Upgradation of 33 kV Intake Sub-station & Switch Yard, Master Control Sub-station and Berth-6 Sub-station [formerly Phosphate Berth Sub-station] of Haldia Dock Complex, Syama Prasad Mookerjee Port, Kolkata, under EPC mode, including 5 years Manning & Comprehensive Maintenance.

Last date & time of online submission: 27.03.2026, up to 15:00 Hrs.

Annual Estimated Cost: ₹ 3618 Lakh excluding GST

For further details please check https://eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app and https://smp.smportkolkata.in and participate in bidding through https://gem.gov.in

MADHYA PRADESH JAL NIGAM
(A Govt. of Madhya Pradesh Undertaking)
8, Arera Hills, Bhopal-462004
Web. : mpjalnigam.mp.gov.in, E-mail : mpjalnigam@mp.gov.in CIN - U41000MP2012SGC028798
NIT No. 31-32/Proc./MPJNM/2025-26 Bhopal, Dated : 27.02.2026

NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER

Online Lump-sum rate bids for Balance work of Lump-Sum Contract for Engineering, Procurement, Construction, Testing, Commissioning, Trial Run and Operation & Maintenance for 10 Years of following Multi Villages Drinking Water Supply Scheme (MVDWSS) are invited from Registered Contractors/firms fulfilling eligibility criteria as specified in tender document. Basic details of MVDWSS are as follows : -

NIT No.	Scheme	District	PAC (Rs. Cr.)	EMD (Rs. Lakh)	Cost of Tender Document (Rs.)	Time for Completion (including Rainy Season) (Months)
31	Balance works of Ghategaon Bhitarwar MVS	Gwalior	272.21	50.00	50,000	24
32	Balance works of SADA MVS	Gwalior	23.15	11.58	50,000	18

Note : The Probable Amount of Contract (PAC) indicated above is approximate. Interested bidders are advised to refer to the uploaded bid document for the exact PAC.
Interested bidders can view/download/purchase the bid document online from M.P. Government E-Procurement Portal from **09.03.2026, 17:30 Hrs.** Bidding process dates mentioned as critical dates on M.P. Government E-Procurement Portal will be applicable. Corrigendum/Addendum in NIT, if any, would be published on portal only and not in newspapers.
M.P. Government E-Procurement Portal - https://mptenders.gov.in
M.P. Madhyam/124830/2026 **MANAGING DIRECTOR**

AHMEDABAD JANMARG LIMITED
(A 100% Subsidiary of Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation)
Registered-Office: Dr. Ramanbhai Patel Bhavan, Usmanpura, Ahmedabad - 380013, Gujarat, India.

TENDER NOTICE NO:- 39/2025-26

Sr. No.	Name of Work	Amount (Excluding GST)
1	CONSTRUCTION OF BUS CHARGING STATION AT CHANDKHEDA, AHMEDABAD (Re-invite)	18,00,08,284.00

Online Tender Submission	Date : 17-03-2026 up to 18:00 hrs.
Physical Bid Submission	Date : 18-03-2026, up to 16.00 hrs.
Details & Tender available on	https://tender.nprocure.com

Executive Director - AJL & Dy. MC. - AMC

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WEST BENGAL STATE ELECTRICITY DISTRIBUTION COMPANY LIMITED
(A Govt. of West Bengal Enterprise)
Regd. Office : Vidyut Bhavan, Block-DJ, Sector-II, Bidhannagar, Kolkata - 700 091
CIN : U40109WB2007SGC113473, www.wbsedcl.in

WBSEDCL invites e-Tender(s) as follows:

NIT No.: WBSEDCL/IT/118.02/2445, **Dt.:** 06.03.2026 of the **Chief Engineer (IT)** for 'Engagement of Implementation Partner-cum-System Integrator (IP) for migration/conversion of SAP ECC (ERP & ISU) to SAP S/4HANA under SaaS model (RISE) and integration with allied SAP System (**2nd Call**)'. ICA- T6446(3)/2026

For details, visit **https://wbtenders.gov.in** & **www.wbsedcl.in**

NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER
GUJARAT GAS

Gujarat Gas Limited (GGL), desires to invite bids against Tender(s) under two bid system through e-tendering portal from eligible and interested parties for the following categories:

Sr. No.	Tender ID	Tender Description	Link for accessing the Tender Documents
1	280421	Rate Contract for supply of various sizes of Commercial & Domestic Riser regulators across GGL locations	• ggltender.nprocure.com • www.gujaratgas.com/ggl-current-tender/
2	282155	PESO Consultancy for Steel Pipeline Network across GGL	
3	275359	Rate Contract for Supply & Installation of Network Switches (24 & 48 Port) at various locations of GGL for a period of two years	
4	281083	Supply & Installation of Backup Appliances at PR & DC of GGL with Licenses for five years	
5	280205	Rate Contract for supply of various sizes of Commercial Diaphragm Meters across GGL Locations	

Any revision, clarifications, corrigenda, addenda, notifications etc. related to this notice will be updated on the above referred websites only. Interested parties should regularly visit websites to keep themselves updated.

M.P. HOUSING & INFRASTRUCTURE DEV. BOARD

NOTICE INVITING TENDER No. 2026_MPHID_487969

Madhya Pradesh Housing & Infrastructure Development Board (MPHIDB) hereby invites online proposals through e-tendering mode from reputed consultants for "Setting up Project Management Unit (PMU) for Project Development and Management Support to MPHIDB"at Bhopal. Selection process will be as per RFP terms and conditions. Online bids are invited from interested bidders as per following details.

Name of Work	Cost of Tender Document	Earnest Money Deposit (EMD)
Selection of consultant for Setting up Project Management Unit (PMU) for Project Development and Management Support to MPHIDB at Bhopal.	Rs. 23,600/- incl. GST	Rs. 10,00,000/-

Note : (1) The bid documents can be purchased online only at **www.mptenders.gov.in** as per schedule : from 10.03.2026 at 10:30 A.M. to 01.04.2026 at 05:30 Hrs. **Last of Bid Submission is 02.04.2026 till 05:30 Hrs.** (2) Pre-proposal meeting will be held **on 17.03.2026 at 03:00 P.M. at 4th floor, Paryawas Bhawan, MPHIDB, HO, Bhopal, Madhya Pradesh**. (3) Interested bidders can view the detailed NIT on website **https//www.mptenders.gov.in**. (4) Key Dates are available on e-tender website. (5) Amendments to NIT if any would be published on website only, and not in newspapers. (6) MPHIDB reserves the right to cancel the tender at any time without assigning any reason.

(Mahendra Singh)
ADDITIONAL HOUSING COMMISSIONER-1
MPHIDB, Bhopal

Visit us : www.mphousing.in /mphidb /mphidb
M.P. Madhyam/124797/2026

How RBI plans to compensate for digital frauds

FROM FRONT FLAP

2 In what situations will the victims of digital payments fraud get the compensation?

The compensation mechanism is aimed at cases where fraud occurs due to third-party breach and despite some degree of customer negligence. The RBI defines this as situations where a customer may have unknowingly shared credentials or been tricked into transferring money. According to the draft guidelines, customer negligence includes actions such as 'providing credentials such as PIN, password, OTP or other details...to another person' or 'downloading malicious apps.' Even in such cases, victims may qualify for partial compensation if they report the fraud quickly. Customers must notify the bank and the National Cyber Crime Helpline or portal within five calendar days for the claim to be eligible.

MINT

3 Who will fund the compensation?

The RBI's framework distributes the burden across the ecosystem. In certain cases, the central bank itself will contribute to the compensation amount along with the issuing and beneficiary banks. For instance, where a compensation of ₹25,000 is paid, the RBI will contribute ₹19,118, while the two banks will contribute ₹2,941 each. For smaller fraud losses, the RBI may bear up to 65% of the compensation, according to the draft rules.

4 Will this framework curb digital fraud?

Allowing compensation for small-value frauds despite some customer negligence is a welcome move, said Manu Zacharia, chief executive officer at HackIT Technology and Advisory Services. "However, the real test will be in implementation, because despite awareness campaigns, digital fraud incidents continue and fraudsters are becoming increasingly sophisticated in using social engineering tactics," Zacharia said. Regulators are trying to balance consumer protection with incentives for customers to remain vigilant while using digital banking channels, he said.

5 What do past trends in digital fraud show?

Digital payment fraud has been a persistent concern. According to RBI's Report on Trend and Progress of Banking in India, banks reported 13,469 fraud cases in card and internet transactions in 2024-25, compared with 27,663 cases in 2023-24. These numbers include frauds of ₹1 lakh and above reported by banks. The data highlights the risks that accompany India's rapid shift to digital payments, and explains why the central bank is now considering stronger consumer protection and compensation mechanisms for victims of online fraud.

AI enters hotel lounges, but humans are staying

AI is making it to energy management, cooling systems and peak-time check-ins

Varuni Khosla
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NEW DELHI

A small robot gliding down a hotel corridor with a tray of amenities may soon become a familiar sight. At properties run by Roseate Hotels & Resorts in Delhi, service robots are already delivering guest requests, helping staff manage routine tasks during busy hours.

Behind the scenes, artificial intelligence (AI) is also analysing incoming calls to identify potential revenue opportunities, track guest preferences and flag complaints.

The next time you step into a hotel, don't expect a robot to greet you at the door, though. A staff member will still open the door, and a chef will still cook your *dal bukhara*, but in the background, AI is already deciding how cool your room should be, how quickly you check in, and even the hotel charges for the night.

Large chains like Radisson Hotel Group and Wyndham Hotels & Resorts are now using data-driven systems for demand forecasting and dynamic pricing, while BWH Hotels, too, is deploying technology across digital platforms to strengthen revenue management and monitor operations.

At Radisson Hotel Group, AI is being piloted across select properties with measurable outcomes. "We are able to optimize costs by around 18-25%," said Nikhil Sharma, managing director and chief operating officer, South Asia.

The chain is deploying AI-driven virtual assistants that allow guests to access 24/7 support through QR-enabled chatbots. Smart room technologies and digital self-service tools speed up check-in and check-out, while giving guests greater control over their rooms. Tools such as Google's Gemini analyse data for demand forecasting and revenue optimization. AI-enabled food waste tracking, for example, is being integrated with property management systems to align supplier orders with occupancy trends.

Large chains like Radisson Hotel Group and Wyndham Hotels & Resorts are now using data-driven systems for demand forecasting and dynamic pricing. ISTOCKPHOTO

Romesh Koul, chief executive officer at Delhi-based Naaz Hotel Consultants Private Ltd, estimates that cost savings could start at 3-4% and expand to 15-20% as AI systems scale.

Adoption so far remains gradual and largely focused on backend systems such as energy optimisation, predictive maintenance, smart sensors and revenue management. "Gradually it has started on a smaller note, but yes it would not overtake the human element. It will help cut project costs and make operations more efficient," Koul said. He likens the technology to installing a revolving door without replacing the doorman. "We still need someone to open the door. Dependence on human staff remains. You still need someone to make the Bukhara dal," Koul said.

Immediate applications of AI tools are already visible in energy management, chillers, occupancy-linked cooling systems and weather-control sensors. Hotels are also experimenting with AI to manage peak-time check-ins.

"We have implemented self check-in solutions and automated room management services, allowing guests to seamlessly access hotel services, schedule requests and personalise their stay with ease," said Kush Kapoor, chief executive officer of Roseate Hotels. The technologies allow hotel teams to respond faster to guest requests while streamlining operations. Roseate is looking at saving anywhere between 12% and 14% from these new ways, Kapoor added.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

HIGH-TECH HOSPITALITY

AI can analyse calls to identify revenue opportunities, track guest preferences and flag complaints

IT can also calculate how cool the room should be, how quickly you check in, and even charges

HOTEL chains are increasingly rolling out AI tools as rising costs, tight margins push for efficiencies

The hikes are being rolled out between February and April. HT

AC prices up 5-15% as input costs rise, rupee weakens

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As the mercury starts rising, leading room air-conditioner makers are increasing prices in the range of 5-15% to offset sustained increases in raw material costs and supply chain expenses.

The hikes, being rolled out between February and April, come just ahead of the peak summer season when demand typically surges. Leading players, including Daikin, Voltas, Blue Star, LG, Haier, and Mitsubishi Heavy Industries, have announced increases across models, passing on higher input costs for key raw materials like copper, a weak rupee, new energy-efficiency norms and increase in freight costs.

Industry executives said while adjustments are unavoidable, they expect strong sales momentum this year, aided by forecasts of a hotter summer and improved energy savings from new star-rated models. Daikin India is going to increase prices by up to 12% from April, and the hike would depend on model to model, its chairman and managing director Kanwaljeet Jawa said.

"The new energy regulations have come, which have made products more efficient. Also, prices of materials such as copper have gone up; the US dollar is at an all-time high (in comparison to the Indian rupee)," he added.

"Besides, there are a lot of uncertainties due to global turmoil, and freight costs have also gone up, making imports (of components) costlier. So, there is no alternative."

There is no escape route for that, and every player in the industry has taken a price increase, Jawa added.

When asked if this hike will impact sales of room airconditioners this year also, he said, "We are expecting a hot summer in 2026. At least it should touch the levels of 2024, when the industry had record sales. I think this year it should see at least a 15% growth." Blue Star MD B. Thiagarajan said the company has already taken a price increase of 8-10% in the middle of February. However, old-priced inventory is still in the market, hence there is not much difference. "Dealers lifted stocks earlier as a price increase was going to happen. They bought in early, so they will be selling the old stock," he said, adding that a new batch, priced higher, will take some time to reach the market.

THE WEEK AHEAD

9-15 MAR — POLL DATES
Election Commission likely to announce assembly poll schedule for four states and one Union Territory.

9 MAR — EXCISE POLICY CASE
Delhi High Court to hear CBI's plea against trial court order discharging Arvind Kejriwal, Manish Sisodia.

9 MAR — SWITCH AUCTION
Reserve Bank of India to conduct switch auction of government securities worth ₹20,000 crore.

11 MAR — US INFLATION PRINT
US CPI data to be released ahead of Fed's interest rate decision on 17-18 March.

11 MAR — ECI-SOCIAL MEDIA MEET
Election Commission to hold first meet with social media firms to tackle misinformation.

12 MAR — INDIA CPI INFLATION
India's retail inflation data for February set to be released.

Fee overhaul to reshape India's mutual fund industry

FROM PAGE 1

comes into effect from April 1.

With GST moving outside BER, compliance under the indirect tax regime will increase. Small distributors not registered for GST will be forced to partner with platforms that can help fulfil compliance requirements.

The move marks a fundamental change for the industry as about 90% of the distributors, who contribute about 40-50% of the mutual fund industry's assets under management (AUM) worth ₹81 trillion, are likely to be non-GST compliant, according to Parth Parekh, head of investor relations and senior research analyst at Prudent Corporate Advisory Services Ltd, which handles assets of ₹1.3 trillion.

There were about 178,000 mutual fund distributors in India as of fiscal 2025, according to the Association of Mutual Funds in India (Amfi). The top three distributors by commissions and expenses paid were NJ India Invest, State Bank of India and HDFC Bank.

"A majority of the industry is not GST registered as of now," said Kartik Sankaran, a mutual fund distributor with Happyness Factory, which handles assets of more ₹4,800 crore.

"There is a very long tail of distributors who do very few transactions in a year," he said. "A small distributor who works with 15 AMCs will have to file 15 GST returns. Platforms can help them with this as they may not have the operational capacity or capital to do the same."

A distributor working for a platform only needs to file one GST bill with the company, which then reaches out to the AMCs the distributor would have worked with to obtain the GST return.

"The shift to platforms will be a gradual move and may not start immediately after April 1. Platforms will also benefit as they will acquire more AUM. How big the shift will be is yet to be seen," said Sankaran.

A process note issued on February 26 by the registrar and transfer agent (RTA), KFin Technologies Ltd, outlines how the transition will work. Asset management companies will provide revised brokerage structures marked "exclusive of GST" starting 1 April.

Commissions will be calculated on these base rates. However, the brokerage paid to distributors will initially exclude GST. The tax will be tracked separately and released only after distributors remit the tax and submit proof through the RTA portal.

The move marks a fundamental change for the industry as about 90% of distributors are likely to be non-GST compliant. ISTOCKPHOTO

The change alters incentives across the distribution chain. Historically, many smaller distributors were not registered under GST but still received commissions that implicitly included the tax component. With commissions paid net of the tax, those distributors may effectively see lower payouts unless they become compliant.

Small distributors not registered for GST will be forced to partner with platforms that can help with compliance

If an asset management company pays 100 basis points (bps) in commission, inclusive of GST, that amount includes the base payout and the tax component. Since GST on distribution services is 18%, the embedded tax would be about 15.25 basis points (bps), leaving a base commission of roughly 84.75 bps.

Under the new system, AMCs will initially pay the base commission.

The GST portion will be released separately once distributors registered under GST file their returns and submit proof through the RTA system, while those who are not registered will receive only the base payout.

Those who are not registered will receive only the base payout of about 84.75 bps in the example cited above, creating an effective gap of roughly 15% in earnings compared with GST-compliant distributors.

"There will be a huge consolidation of smaller distributors into platforms. Earlier, non-GST registered distributors would get a 15% arbitrage compared to those who are registered; now this has reversed," said Parekh.

Mutual fund distributors attract an 18% GST. Small distributors with an annual turnover of up to ₹50 lakh can opt for the GST composition scheme, paying 6% tax on turnover but they cannot issue GST tax invoices or claim input tax credit.

Distributors with an annual turnover below ₹20 lakh are not required to register for GST and do not charge the levy.

Oil market chaos set to deepen as more Gulf giants cut output

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The chaos that has gripped the oil market looks set to deepen in the coming days, with more production being shut off as the war in Iran keeps the Strait of Hormuz closed to tankers, and the US considers widening its range of targets in the country.

The United Arab Emirates and Kuwait have started reducing oil production as storage runs down, joining Iraq. Others may be forced to follow as oil tankers continue avoiding the narrow waterway, rapidly reducing the number of empty ones available for loading. Once all the tankers are loaded, the region's remaining on-land storage will fill even quicker.

The upheaval, now in its ninth day, shows no sign of imminent resolution, meaning a strip of water that normally handles a fifth of the world's oil is impassable for commercial ships. About a third of the region's production can theoretically bypass Hormuz, with Saudi Arabia already diverting huge amounts of crude to its Red Sea coast for export.

Iran has vowed not to back down in the face of US and Israeli strikes that began on Feb. 28. US President Donald Trump responded on Saturday by saying the US would now consider targeting areas and groups of people in Iran that were not previously aimed for.

For oil analysts, executives and traders, that has meant ever-louder warnings that the war is bringing crude to a tipping point, and closer to the psychological $100-a-barrel threshold. Brent already climbed 30% last week—its biggest jump in six years, putting it just dollars from that mark.

Other markers tied closely to the region have already soared through that level. Futures tied to Abu Dhabi's flagship Murban crude closed at $103 a barrel on Friday, while Oman crude futures were at $107. Chinese crude oil futures on the Shanghai International Energy Exchange ended, in US dollar terms, at $109.

Only Iran-linked tankers and two carriers, claiming to be Chinese, were seen transiting through the Strait of Hormuz recently. REUTERS

"Every additional day of disruption adds pressure, and in that scenario there is effectively no ceiling to prices in the short term," said former trader Stefano Grasso, a senior portfolio manager at Singapore-based fund 8VantEdge Pte.

For one, there are growing threats to oil infrastructure — raising risk of disruptions that could outlast attacks. Saudi Arabia intercepted drones that were heading toward the 1-million-barrel-a-day Shaybah oil field over the weekend. Strikes in Bahrain and Qatar have also continued.

There is also the continued blockage of the Strait of Hormuz. Over the past days, only Iran-linked tankers and two bulk carriers, claiming to be Chinese-owned, have been seen transiting.

The US has promised to bolster financial protection and potentially provide military escorts, and announced on Friday that it would roll out maritime reinsurance for the Persian Gulf region. The facility will cover losses up to about $20 billion "on a rolling basis", according to a statement.

For shipowners and charterers operating in the region, however, the cost of insurance is not the major concern holding up traffic. Instead, they worry about the safety of vessels and crew, and say they would need full naval escort—along the lines of Operation Prosperity Guardian, a coalition to safeguard shipping in the Red Sea—or preferably an end to hostilities.

Other US moves to dampen oil price increases include allowing India to access Russian oil currently held in floating storage in the region. Washington has also floated tapping its strategic petroleum reserve or even intervening in futures markets—officials have since downplayed these ideas, while Trump has brushed off inflationary worries even as US gasoline prices spike.

Import-dependent Asia, which leans heavily on the Middle East, is feeling the most immediate pain.

SLIPPERY SLOPE

UAE and Kuwait started reducing oil production as storage runs down, joining Iraq

THE upheaval, which is now in its ninth day, is showing no sign of imminent resolution

Aramco shares surge most since 2023

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Saudi Aramco jumped the most since May 2023 on Sunday as the Iran war entered its second week, prompting supply disruptions that may send oil prices higher when global markets reopen.

Shares of the state-backed oil giant climbed as much as 4.9% intraday in Riyadh, on the first day of trading for the stock since Brent crude prices topped $90 a barrel on Friday.

Brent, the global benchmark, may climb further in the days ahead after the United Arab Emirates (UAE) and Kuwait started reducing oil production amid a near-closure of the vital Strait of Hormuz waterway, adding to interruptions affecting worldwide energy supply and exports.

"For Aramco, we believe that the gain in oil prices would offset a decline in exports," said Junaid Ansari, head of research and strategy at Kamco Investment Co. "We also believe that Aramco should be able to re-route a bulk of its shipments to the Red Sea. It's just about logistics and handling the excess capacity."

Last week, the state oil producer raised the price of its main oil grade for buyers in Asia for April by the most since August 2022 amid the turmoil in the Middle East.

While Aramco has been redirecting oil cargoes to Red Sea facilities at Yanbu on Saudi Arabia's west coast to avoid the chokepoint, Goldman Sachs cautioned on Friday that the firm's capacity to do so may be limited. The world's largest oil producer saw more of its fields under attack over the weekend.

Can Lloyds replicate its India success in Congo?

MD Gupta says the Congo bet mirrors the firm's early days in Gadchiroli

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After setting up mining operations in a Maoist conflict-prone region in India, Lloyds Metals and Energy Ltd is betting it can replicate that success in the volatile Katanga region of the Democratic Republic of the Congo.

The mining company is targeting copper production in a region long considered both resource-rich and operationally challenging, where regulatory uncertainty, weak infrastructure and political risks have complicated operations for global miners.

Managing director Rajesh Gupta said the Congo bet mirrors the company's early days in Maharashtra's Gadchiroli. "When we expanded our operations in Gadchiroli, the region was considered difficult and impossible," Gupta said during an earnings call in February. Over time, the same narrative will emerge for Katanga and other parts of the world, he added.

The move comes as copper demand is expected to surge globally amid electrification, renewable energy and grid expansion, even as supply remains constrained. Global benchmark copper prices are currently at $11,000-12,000 per tonne, jumping a little over 30% over the last one year.

Drawing a parallel between operating a mine in Gadchiroli and in Congo is not entirely fair, said Suman Kumar, assistant vice-president for metals and mining at brokerage Philip Capital. In India, companies understand regulatory and political ecosystem, but in foreign jurisdictions, especially parts of Africa, execution risks are far higher, said the sell-side analyst. He pointed to examples of Indian companies that struggled to scale overseas mining projects, including Jindal Steel and Power Ltd in Mozambique and Vedanta Ltd's challenges at Konkola Copper Mines in Zambia.

"Even companies with significantly deeper financial muscle have struggled. So any guidance on timelines or margins, particularly projections like 30% Ebitda by FY27, should be viewed cautiously. It is easier said than done," Kumar said.

Meanwhile, Vedanta, in an email response, said its Zambia mines are raising production, with an average monthly output of around 8,000 tonnes. Multiple mining companies have faced operational and commercial challenges in Congo, said Satnam Singh, senior practice leader & director, Crisil Intelligence.

"China Molybdenum temporarily halted exports from its Tenke Fungurume copper-cobalt mine after disputes over export licences and taxation with state authorities, illustrating how regulatory uncertainty can interrupt production and contracts," Singh said.

Commodities giant Glencore is in protracted negotiations with the Congolese government over joint venture terms and is currently in talks for a stake sale to a US-based consortium to reduce country risk, he added. According to Crisil, Congo holds about 8% of global copper reserves and is the world's second-largest producer, accounting for 14% of global output, behind Chile at 23%.

For an extended version of the story, go to livemint.com

Lloyds is targeting copper production in a region long considered both resource-rich and operationally challenging. BLOOMBERG

EXPANDING OPERATIONS

THE move comes as copper demand is expected to surge globally amid electrification

WEAK infra, political risks in Congo have complicated operations for global miners

CONGO holds about 8% of global copper reserves and is the second-largest producer globally

Why Reliance is betting on legacy regional FMCG brands

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While many consumer goods companies are acquiring direct-to-consumer (D2C) startups, Reliance Consumer Products Ltd (RCPL) is pursuing a different playbook.

The consumer arm of billionaire Mukesh Ambani's Reliance Industries has been steadily buying regional legacy brands with strong local recall. By plugging these brands into Reliance's vast retail and distribution ecosystem, the firm hopes to accelerate its ambition of becoming an FMCG (fast-moving consumer goods) powerhouse.

During the December quarter, RCPL's overall gross revenue stood at ₹5,065 crore, up 60% year-on-year, according to an earnings statement from Reliance Industries.

India's FMCG sector remains dominated by established players such as Hindustan Unilever Ltd, which reported revenue of about ₹64,138 crore in FY25—highlighting the scale of the opportunity Reliance is targeting as it builds its consumer business.

"What Reliance is doing is cobbling together a portfolio of brands that already have some momentum," said Arvind Singhal, chairman of The Knowledge Company, a Gurugram-based management consulting firm.

Mint explains the strategy behind Reliance's push to acquire regional brands and how it differs from rivals.

Which regional brands has Reliance acquired?

Over the past few years, RCPL has assembled a portfolio of regional brands across food, beverages and personal care.

One of its latest additions is Chennai-based Southern Health Foods Pvt. Ltd, which sells millet-based foods, health mixes and baby nutrition products under the Manna brand.

Earlier, RCPL bought a majority stake in Udhaiyam Agro Foods Pvt. Ltd, a Tamil Nadu-based staples brand known for pulses, flours, spices and ready-to-cook mixes.

Reliance has also acquired Delhi-based SIL, a legacy condiments maker known for jams, sauces and cooking pastes, as well as Velvette, the historic personal care label that pioneered shampoo sachets in India in the 1980s.

In beverages, RCPL revived Campa Cola, acquired from the Pure Drinks Group, in the carbonated drinks segment.

What do regional brands gain from partnering with Reliance?

Regional brands that partner with or are acquired by Reliance gain access to scale that is often difficult to achieve independently.

Many local brands enjoy strong loyalty in their home markets but face constraints such as limited capital, weaker supply chains and restricted distribution networks.

Under the Reliance umbrella, these brands gain access to the group's nationwide retail and distribution ecosystem, which includes millions of kirana stores as well as large-format retail chains operated by Reliance Retail. This enables them to expand beyond their regional strongholds far faster than they could independently.

Why is Reliance pursuing this strategy?

For RCPL, acquiring regional brands offers a faster and potentially less risky way to expand in India's vast FMCG market. The strategy also allows Reliance to quickly build a diverse portfolio across staples, beverages and personal care—strengthening its ability to compete with established FMCG giants such as Hindustan Unilever and ITC.

How are rival FMCG companies expanding instead?

Most traditional FMCG companies are pursuing a different strategy by acquiring or investing in digital-first D2C brands.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

The consumer arm of Reliance Industries has been steadily buying regional legacy brands with strong local recall. MINT

EXPLAINER

OpenAI's robotics head resigns over company's Pentagon deal

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The head of OpenAI's robotics team resigned Saturday, citing the company's deal to deploy its artificial intelligence (AI) models within the Pentagon's classified network as the cause.

"This wasn't an easy call," Caitlin Kalinowski wrote in a post on X. "AI has an important role in national security. But surveillance of Americans without judicial oversight and lethal autonomy without human authorization are lines that deserved more deliberation than they got."

OpenAI confirmed Kalinowski's departure in an email statement and said it believes the agreement with the Defense Department "creates a workable path for responsible national security uses of AI while making clear our red lines, no domestic surveillance and no autonomous weapons."

"We recognize that people have strong views about these issues and we will continue to engage in discussion with employees, government, civil society and communities around the world," the company said.

TechCrunch previously reported Kalinowski's resignation.

Kalinowski joined OpenAI in November 2024 as a member of the company's technical staff in robotics after leading development of augmented reality glasses for Meta, according to her LinkedIn profile.

OpenAI struck its deal with the Pentagon in late February following the breakdown of talks between the Trump administration and Anthropic PBC, which pressed for assurances that its technology wouldn't be used for mass surveillance of Americans or for fully autonomous weapons. OpenAI hasn't said whether its services for the Pentagon will replace the work previously done by Anthropic.

President Donald Trump ordered all government departments to stop working with Anthropic, and the Pentagon declared the company and its products a supply-chain risk. Anthropic, in turn, has said it would challenge the designation—which previously was reserved for entities of adversary nations such as China's Huawei Technologies Co.—in court.

OpenAI chief executive officer Sam Altman said earlier this month that the company's rush to reach a deal with the Defense Department looked "opportunistic and sloppy." OpenAI also publicly disagreed with the blacklisting of Anthropic.

OpenAI struck its deal with the Pentagon in late Feb. REUTERS

Arnya, Supreme raise ₹1,030 cr for fund

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Investment manager Arnya Real Estates Fund Advisors and developer Supreme Universal have raised ₹1,030 crore for Arnya Real Estate Fund—Equity, from domestic and offshore investors, including family offices and ultra-rich individuals, marking the first close for the equity platform.

The capital raised also includes ₹220 crore of equity committed by the two sponsors. Arnya Real Estates will manage the fund, while Mumbai-based Supreme Universal will develop the projects.

Arnya Real Estates has raised the capital for the platform via a Sebi-registered category II alternative investment fund (AIF)—Arnya Real Estate Fund-Equity.

The two partners had announced the launch of a residential real estate platform in November that will develop housing projects in Mumbai and Pune. The total target corpus of the fund is ₹1,250 crore.

The fund will focus on developing society redevelopment projects in Mumbai, which has seen a huge spurt in activity in recent years. The platform is expected to have around seven to eight projects, with an investment of ₹80-200 crore each.

"Equity investments in residential real estate are hardly happening. Yet, the requirement for capital is huge because developers are expanding. Real estate projects need capital, including debt and equity, at various stages of their life cycle. However, the source of capital for residential developers is quite limited," Sharad Mittal, founder and CEO, Arnya Real Estates Fund Advisors told *Mint*.

"Mumbai's residential redevelopment segment represents one of the most scalable and structurally resilient business models in Indian real estate. Through this fund, we are providing investors with a structured and transparent vehicle to participate," Mittal added.

The fund is evaluating the first two transactions, both Mumbai redevelopment projects.

Sunny Bijlani, joint managing director, Supreme Universal said that as the real estate sector evolves, the quality and structure of capital have become as important as execution capability.

"Institutional partnerships such as this bring discipline and transparency into redevelopment projects," he added. Arnya's equity fund follows the launch of its real estate debt fund. In 2024, it launched its maiden real estate fund—Arnya Real Estate Fund-Debt—aiming to raise ₹1,000 crore, *Mint* had reported.

So far, ₹425 crore has been committed across seven transactions in Mumbai, Pune, Bengaluru and Chennai. "Our objective is to build a focused, institutional real estate asset management platform led by experienced real estate investment professionals, ensuring disciplined capital allocation," Mittal added.

The Arnya Real Estate Fund—Equity will focus on developing society redevelopment projects in Mumbai. BLOOMBERG

The platform is expected to have around seven to eight projects, with an investment of ₹80-200 cr each

Cos see food delivery regain growth momentum

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India's top three food delivery players—Swiggy, magicpin and Zomato—regained growth momentum in October-December after a period of slower expansion, on strong order volumes led by festive demand, affordability-focused offerings and expanding user bases.

With continued investments in marketing, product innovation, and value-led propositions, industry executives said the sector expects the momentum in order growth to sustain in the coming quarters.

"It has been a phenomenal October-November-December quarter for us, marked by strong growth and sharper execution across markets. Our unit economics at an order level have improved by over 60%, reflecting greater efficiency and improved monetization," magicpin founder and chief executive officer (CEO) Anshoo Sharma said.

While mature markets such as Delhi-NCR remained steady, the firm saw over 40% growth in gross order value (GOV) in cities, including Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Mumbai.

As per Swiggy's Q3FY26 shareholder letter, the firm's GOV grew 20.5% on-year to ₹8,959 crore, marking the fastest growth in the last three years. Swiggy said the acceleration was driven by stronger adoption of new propositions across speed, selection and affordability.

Zomato's food delivery business also reported improving growth trends during the quarter under review.

The company posted 16.6% year-on-year net order value growth at ₹9,846 crore in the December quarter translating into 21.3% growth in GOV.

Contracts bring clause for promoting films as part of release strategy

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As theatrical films compete with OTT (over-the-top) content and other entertainment options for audience attention, promotional campaigns have become a central part of a film's release strategy, often with actors contractually required to participate.

A recent dispute in the Malayalam film industry has brought that shift into focus. The Kerala Film Producers' Association (KFPA) has asked actor Biju Menon to pay a compensation of about ₹15 lakh to cover the alleged loss incurred by the producer of his movie *Nadanna Sambhavam*, after the actor allegedly failed to appear for promotions as required under his contract.

Queries sent to the actor on Saturday requesting a comment remained unanswered. The producer, Anoop Kananan, has said that the contract required lead actors to dedicate 10 days to promotion, but Menon only appeared for a few hours.

In an earlier interview with *Mint*, actor Aamir Khan stressed the importance of marketing and promotional events, saying actors and crews must step out to make audiences aware of a film, since such outreach cannot be done "in their living rooms." Industry experts say such disputes highlight how marketing has become deeply embedded in the economics of filmmaking, with promotional duties increasingly written into actor contracts alongside performance obligations.

Promotional requirements are now specifically mentioned in actor contracts with the number of days included in their fee, as compared to about a decade ago, when there were fewer activities planned and actors were simply expected to take time out for them. Industry executives estimate that 20-30% of a film's marketing budget goes into promotional events.

From a legal standpoint, a film project is typically governed by a contract that includes express terms regarding promotional duties. If an actor signs such a contract and then fails to honour it, the producer can claim contractual breach and seek remedies—most commonly damages proportionate to the quantifiable loss the producer alleges to have suffered. That said, promotions come with advantages and downsides, particularly if they become excessive.

"In contemporary film contracts, participation in pre-release promotional activities is no longer a mere courtesy—it's increasingly a negotiated, contractual obligation that materially affects a project's commercial ecosystem," said Tushar Agarwal, founder and managing partner, C.L.A.P. JURIS, Advocates & Solicitors.

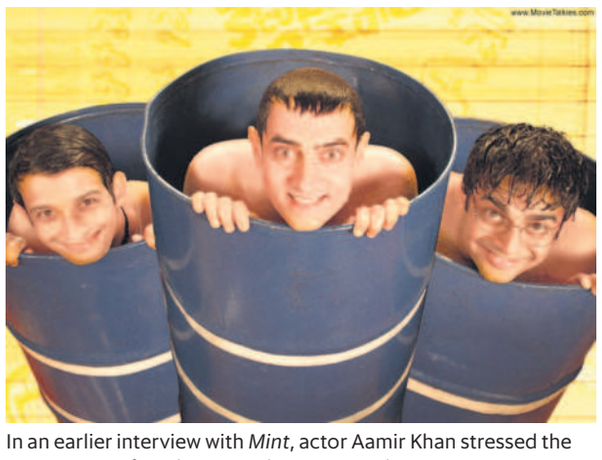
"Producers and distributors value star appearances at press meets, interviews and media circuits because such visibility drives marketability and can directly influence downstream revenue streams such as television and digital rights."

Agarwal added that the key is that such preferences must be transparently negotiated before signing the agreement. Promotions today sit at the intersection of storytelling and commerce, according to Abhishek S. Vyas, founder and chief executive officer of AVS, an arts and entertainment company.

A film is no longer competing only with other theatrical releases, Vyas said. It is competing with streaming platforms, gaming, social media, and global content available instantly to audiences.

In that environment, promotional participation by actors becomes an extension of the narrative itself, he added.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.



In an earlier interview with *Mint*, actor Aamir Khan stressed the importance of marketing and promotional events.

Promotional requirements are now mentioned in actor contracts with the number of days included in their fees

Iran is hitting the radars that underpin U.S. missile defenses

Jared Malsin & Milàn Czerny

Iran is targeting the radar systems that serve as the eyes of the air defenses in the Middle East, hitting several in recent days and degrading the ability of the U.S. and its allies to track incoming missiles.

Iranian strikes in retaliation for the U.S. and Israeli bombing campaign have hit radar, communications and air defense systems in Qatar, the U.A.E., Jordan, Bahrain, Kuwait and Saudi Arabia, according to U.S. officials, military analysts and commercially available satellite images.

The strikes are often carried out by Iran's one-way attack drones, such as its Shaheds, which are a fraction of the cost of the missiles that the sophisticated U.S. systems were designed to defend against. Iran has fired fewer missiles in recent days.

"Overall, our defenses are doing quite well. That said, it is clear that the Iranians have a sense of what type of targets they want to continue to press against, and that includes command and control and our ability to detect inbound missiles and drones," said Ravi Chaudhary , a former assistant secretary of the Air Force in charge of installations.

A spokesman for U.S. Central Command said the military remained at full combat capability despite the hits. The U.S. has been bolstering its defenses in the region, sending in more equipment and interceptors, U.S. officials said.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

The U.S. says it is degrading Iran's ability to launch attacks by the day. Adm. Brad Cooper, commander of U.S. forces in the Middle East, said Thursday that ballistic-missile attacks had decreased by 90% and drone attacks had dropped by 83% since the war began.

The U.S. and its partners in the region use a network of Thaads, Patriots and other air-defense systems to shoot down missiles, drones and rockets fired by Iran and its allied militias in the region.

Those air defense batteries depend on radar to detect incoming missiles and drones. Those systems are often rare and expensive. The conflict has also chewed through U.S. stocks of interceptors it uses to fend off missiles.

One of the most significant strikes hit a sophisticated early-warning radar system at Qatar's Al-Udeid, which hosts the largest American military base in the region. The attack damaged the AN/FPS-132 radar, hindering its ability to function, according to satellite imagery and a U.S. official.

Tehran is carrying out many of the strikes with one-way attack drones. AP

The AN/FPS-132 is a wide-aperture radar designed to track many targets at once. The U.S. has five of these fixed radar systems in its North American warning system that is set up to protect the U.S. homeland from potential incoming missiles, according to the International Institute for Strategic Studies, a defense think tank. The system costs up to $1 billion.

"These are scarce, strategic resources," said Thomas Karako , the director of the Missile Defense Project at the Center for Strategic and International Studies in Washington.

Satellite images from Planet Labs show damage to the radar installation in Qatar. The images show debris on the northeastern face of the domed radar installation, the side facing Iran, along with water runoff, likely from efforts to put out a fire, according to Sam Lair, a researcher with the James Martin Center for Nonproliferation Studies.

"It demonstrates the fragility of some of these kind of higher tier radars," said Lair, who published an analysis of the satellite image.

Iran also struck a TPY-2 radar attached to a Thaad battery in Jordan, according to satellite imagery and a U.S. official. The radar is a critical component of the ground-based missile-defense system, which intercepts ballistic missiles above the atmosphere.

Satellite images reviewed by The Wall Street Journal also show damage to three radar domes at Camp Arifjan, a base used by U.S. forces in Kuwait, and damage to a satellite communications system at the headquarters of the U.S. Fifth Fleet in Bahrain.

In Saudi Arabia, a satellite image taken on March 1 shows smoke billowing from a building at a radar site at the kingdom's Prince Sultan Air Base.

The U.S. has deployed its key radar systems in strategic locations around the world to protect against threats from Iran, North Korea, Russia and other adversaries. The Navy also has several guided-missile destroyers in the region, which can also shoot down ballistic missiles and other aerial threats.

Those systems have played an important role in the current conflict with Iran. When Iran fired a missile at a Turkish military base where the U.S. stores nuclear weapons, a U.S. radar system in southeastern Turkey detected the incoming fire and relayed the threat to an American warship in the eastern Mediterranean that shot the missile down. The radar station in the town of Kürecik had been placed there more than a decade earlier by the Obama administration to bolster NATO air defenses against Iran.

The U.S. Army has only seven operational Thaad batteries in total, including two that are based long-term in Guam and South Korea. Of the U.S.'s five rotating Thaads, two are currently in the Middle East—in Israel and Jordan—to counter Iranian threats. An eighth Thaad was delivered to the U.S. last year but is still undergoing testing, officials said.

Saudi Arabia and the U.A.E. have also purchased their own Thaad systems from the U.S. and have said some of them are operational.

In many of the attacks, Iran has used one-way attack drones that explode on impact. Flying low and slow, the drones are difficult to defend against for some more-traditional air defenses. The drones have played a central role in Iran's retaliation, hitting oil facilities, military bases and high-rise buildings in the Gulf.

Iran is firing fewer missiles than it did in its initial wave of attacks in response to the U.S. and Israeli offensive, but its drone attacks have largely continued at a steady pace. After an initial wave of more than 500 drones in the first two days of the conflict, the U.A.E. has been targeted by more than 100 drones every day, according to its defense ministry.

Both sides have limitations on their stockpiles of munitions. Senior Pentagon officials before the war raised concerns that the U.S. and its allies have a limited supply of air defense interceptors. U.S. Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth has said the U.S. has sufficient munitions for the conflict.

Iran is believed to have the capacity to produce thousands of drones, which it has also exported to Russia. Moscow has used Iranian drones and similar models it has produced in Russia for its strikes on Ukraine. Russia is also sharing intelligence with Iran that it could use to help target military forces.

"The problem of complex and integrated air and missile attack is here, and we have to contend with the full spectrum of air missile threats, not just the ballistic stuff," said Karako. "You have to have defense for your defenses."

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How the OpenAI-Anthropic feud could warp the future of AI

A fractured Amodei-Altman relationship will color the debate on how AI should develop

Tim Higgins
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Sam Altman (left) and Dario Amodei, the CEOs of OpenAI and Anthropic. AFP

The last time Sam Altman and Dario Amodei stood on stage together, they awkwardly tried to avoid physical contact even as other tech leaders held hands aloft for a group photo with India's prime minister.

They looked like pouting kids on the playground—not the CEOs of OpenAI and Anthropic, two of the hottest names in the AI scene. To many, the odd exchange was the physical manifestation of the growing rivalry between the companies. Both have been eyeing going public this year and, in doing so, are fighting each other for users, talent and investor dollars.

That dust-up was a couple of weeks ago. Things have only grown more heated as the men and their companies have tried to claim the moral high ground in conflicting dealings with the Pentagon.

American business and Silicon Valley, in particular, are littered with classic beefs fueled by ambition, greed and green-eyed jealousy: the late Steve Jobs vs. Bill Gates; Apple vs. Samsung; Uber vs. Lyft. Then there's Elon Musk vs., well, everyone—Jeff Bezos, Mark Zuckerberg, even Altman.

Arguably such spirited rivalries can be good for consumers in the long run. Each side is trying to outinnovate, outprice, outcompete the other. But the OpenAI-Anthropic feud carries a unique risk with the fate of the still-nascent AI technology resting in just a few powerful hands.

The toxic turn between OpenAI and Anthropic fuels distrust and threatens to further rupture consensus around still-evolving safety practices. It will color public debate around how the technology should be used and influenced.

Heightened tensions exploded into view in recent days as each company tried to navigate its own relationship with the Pentagon and its demands for control over AI. The messy dance saw Anthropic lose its business with the government while OpenAI gained new ground. The raw bitterness displayed between the rivals underscores the challenge the companies will have working together.

"This is not the last time we will see state interference into frontier AI, and until we build formalized structures for such interference it will be important for the industry to hang tough together," Dean Ball , a former Trump administration AI adviser, posted on X . "I fear that will be less likely now."

Anthropic was famously born in 2021 out of safety concerns that Amodei—then OpenAI's vice president of research—had about his employer's approach to AI.

Whereas Altman can be seen as a wheeler-dealer, racing to cut big deals to grow fast, Amodei staked out a comparably measured position—almost academic or, some might say, zealous. He is known for voicing concerns around the potential dark side of the power he is developing, warning of Great Depression-like job losses.

To be fair, Altman, too, voices concerns, but in an almost gee-whiz wonderment that leaves no doubt he's on the side of the robot.

Not surprisingly, the two have been on opposite sides of policy debates around regulation. For example, in California, Anthropic backed a first-of-its kind law aimed at providing some sort of guardrails. The measure was widely decried by many in tech, who warned it would unleash patchwork regulation that would stymie AI development.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

As this year began and it became clear both companies were thinking about IPOs, Amodei started taking some veiled shots at OpenAI. This appeared to be an effort to draw a finer line between the two.

Amodei, in January at Davos, essentially questioned the ethics of AI companies run by leaders who came out of social media. That was an unnamed swipe at Altman, who dropped out of Stanford University to co-found a social-network startup and later became a big backer of Reddit.

In early February, Anthropic launched a marketing campaign, including Super Bowl commercials , which took aim at OpenAI's plans, without specifically naming the company, to bring ads to its chatbot.

Altman responded that the ads were dishonest. "I guess it's on brand for Anthropic doublespeak to use a deceptive ad to critique theoretical deceptive ads that aren't real," Altman posted on X.

It felt as if the smaller Anthropic was on the ascent, threatening to outshine OpenAI.

By month's end, the stakes between the companies had grown even bigger when Amodei rejected Pentagon efforts to get Anthropic to throw out its redlines on using its technology for mass domestic surveillance and fully autonomous weapons.

The principled stand threw Anthropic's business into jeopardy. The federal government not only banned its use, but Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth labeled the company a supply-chain risk. Such a designation threatens Anthropic's ability to transact with companies doing business with the U.S. government.

Then Altman swooped in to cut his own deal with the Pentagon about the same time he went public in apparent support of Anthropic's position. While Altman characterized his arrangement as safeguarding OpenAI's own similar redlines, the move was seen as, at best, opportunistic.

In the wake of that, Amodei dashed off an emotional note to his staff that took aim at OpenAI and its claims ("the mendacious nature of it" as he began in the message reported by The Information, the tech publication).

"Mendacious" is a five-dollar word for lying.

"We haven't given dictator-style praise to Trump (while Sam has)," Amodei continued. "We have supported AI regulation which is against their agenda, we've told the truth about a number of AI policy issues (like job displacement), and we've actually held our red lines with integrity rather than colluding with them to produce 'safety theater' for the benefit of employees...."

After the message became public this past week, Amodei apologized for the memo's tone and said his thinking had changed.

Unsurprisingly, the unvarnished thoughts couldn't be put back into the bottle. In return, Altman took his own swipe at his rival in a public setting. "The government is supposed to be more powerful than private companies," he said at a Morgan Stanley conference Thursday.

The irony is that the two men can often sound similar when they talk about AI—its rapid acceleration and game-changing future. Both agree something big is coming. Soon.

Following the blowup with the Pentagon, Amodei told CBS News that Congress should weigh in on how AI could be used for mass surveillance in ways that he suggested haven't caught up with current laws. Similarly, on Thursday, Altman said elected officials should determine how AI is used in national defense.

Still, it's hard to imagine the two lobbying hand in hand soon.

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Iran's historic capital is Ground Zero for the U.S.-Israeli air war

Benoit Faucon & Hamraz Bayan

The U.S.-Israeli air war on Iran is leaving a trail of destruction across the capital of Tehran, spreading a sense of dread and paranoia across a 1,000-year-old city that has seen war before but never anything like this.

The first missiles fired in the war on Feb. 28 exploded in the center of Tehran and have rarely let up. Over eight days of conflict, over a third of at least 705 locations struck across Iran were located in Tehran, according to Human Rights Activists in Iran, a nonprofit tracking the war.

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

The U.S.-Israeli focus on the sprawling capital is part of a decapitation strategy that began with the 30 munitions that killed Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and a host of senior leaders . It has continued with the destruction of hundreds of sites, including an underground bunker on Friday, connected to Iran's military and security institutions, which are all run from Tehran.

But the campaign has also hit fuel tanks, cultural heritage sites, sports stadiums and tourist attractions. Golestan Palace, the former royal residence dating back to the 16th century and a World Heritage site, was damaged when airstrike shock waves shattered glass and caused debris to fall in the building.

Late Saturday, strikes set fire on oil storage tanks at a refinery in the south of the capital, the first time energy infrastructure was hit. A Tehran resident said explosions at the depot violently shook his apartment windows. When he stood to see what happened, he could see a massive wall of fire in the distance.

The airstrikes have hit dozens of local units of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps and its volunteer militia, the Basij, an attempt to tear down the regime's repression apparatus and ensure the safety of protesters who rose up in December before a brutal crackdown . But those security forces are located in busy residential areas, often causing collateral damage, residents said.

More than 1,200 civilian Iranians have been killed in the conflict, Human Rights Activists in Iran said, more than twice the number in the 12-day war with Israel last summer.

The U.S. and Israeli military say they aren't targeting civilians. On Friday, U.S. Central Command—which is overseeing the war—said it had targeted command centers, military headquarters, air-defense systems, the navy, ballistic missile sites and military communications centers, among other things.

Tehran residents, known as Tehranis, said the city was functioning but thinned out after a mass exodus of people who had the means to leave and secure a place elsewhere. Those who venture outside are finding that Tehran's streets—normally clogged with soul-crushing traffic—are empty in some neighborhoods. There are only motorcycles zipping around the rubble.

Residents described a tense, surreal atmosphere across the metropolis of 17 million people. Missiles regularly streak across the sky. Explosions have become part of everyday life, rocking their homes.

Tehranis have taken to gathering on the rooftops of high-rise apartment buildings to watch airstrikes through the night, sharing food and drinks and filming explosions that light up the night sky.

"It's like an absurd picnic," one woman in Tehran said.

Golestan Palace was damaged by debris and shock waves from nearby airstrikes. REUTERS

"People sit, eat snacks and ask each other where the missile hit."

There was a feeling of exhilaration when the bombing began as people who hated the Islamic regime began to believe it could finally be toppled. But those emotions are now mixed with a sense of anxiety and disbelief as the airstrikes continue without a foreseeable end.

The regime's security forces are still out in force on the capital's streets, often in plainclothes, masked, and blending in with civilians, residents said. The Basij has set up checkpoints where armed men search each vehicle's trunk for satellite dishes, weapons and anything else suspicious, Tehran residents said.

The city's regular police force has been hit by airstrikes for a week. Some police officers are sleeping in cars out of fear of missiles hitting their homes or station houses, residents said. Shopkeepers have been told to shut down before nightfall, as the police can't respond to robberies, looting or other crimes.

The Ministry of Intelligence is sending text messages to all mobile phones in the city, warning that anyone taking pictures of damaged buildings could be an Israeli spy and asking citizens Wednesday to turn in neighbors for "any suspicious movements."

Late Friday, Iran's police chief, Ahmad-Reza Radan , ordered his forces to shoot looters on sight, according to a text message sent to Iranian mobile subscribers. If "officers encounter thieves, armed confrontation is on the agenda," the communication said.

A second message said police had taken the "firm decision to not appease" protesters, saying some had "plans to kill." It advised families "to take care of their youth and teenagers."

The campaign has also hit fuel tanks, cultural heritage sites, sports stadiums and tourist attractions in Iran

Tehran has never experienced an intense bombing campaign in such a short period. In the 1980s, Iraqi dictator Saddam Hussein bombed Iranian cities with jet fighters and missiles to pressure Iran into a cease-fire. Aerial bombings by Iraq over Tehran in 1986 killed 422 people over a one-year period. During another campaign in 1988, Tehran was hit by at least 118 missiles over 52 days, killing hundreds.

By contrast, the Israeli military, backed by a formidable U.S. military arsenal deployed in the region, struck 500 military targets in Iran on just the first day of the conflict.

"The Iran-Iraq war in the 1980s involved two regional powers for most of its duration," said Farzin Nadimi , an Iran-focused senior fellow with the Washington Institute, a U.S.-based think tank. "Iran is now facing a military superpower, the U.S., and the most powerful military in the Middle East, Israel, together."

Airstrikes have hit the heart of civilian life, inflicting damage on hospitals, schools and residential buildings, according to state media, witnesses and videos verified by Storyful, which is owned by News Corp, parent of The Wall Street Journal.

The Coordination Council of Iranian Educators' Associations, a teachers trade union, called on the U.S. and Israel to ensure that no civilians would be hit in their strikes.

"Schools and hospitals must be safe and nonmilitary zones; places for education, treatment, and care, not war targets," it said on social media Wednesday. The council has supported anti-regime protests and continues to report about arrests of government opponents.

Some of these strikes killed security forces, which are sometimes embedded in civilian facilities and blend in with the population as volunteer paramilitaries.

On Thursday, a strike flattened the Besat stadium, which normally hosts volleyball games. Afterward, security officers were filmed laying on the pavement, injured, inside the sports venue, according to videos verified by Storyful. Military experts said the men's attire was consistent with Iran's so-called counterterrorism Special Force, which played a key role in the deadly crackdown on protesters in January.

Grocery stores remain stocked, but the cost of living—already a trigger behind recent protests—is escalating. The government partly blames wartime profiteers and insists there are no shortages of food.

The simple act of buying groceries, residents said, suddenly feels fraught with dangers. One Tehran woman said an airstrike hit a fruit shop shortly after she left it.

"I can't shake the thought that if the shop had been open that day, I might have been killed," she said.

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NEWS IN NUMBERS

67%
THE SHARE of women professionals in India who say pay parity exists at their workplaces, found a Naukri.com survey of 50,000 women across 50+ industries.

$500 mn
THE SIZE of SBI's new syndicated social term loan facility focused on women's empowerment, with a greenshoe option to expand if demand is strong.

$692 mn
THE SALARY Google CEO Sundar Pichai could potentially earn over the next three years under Alphabet's new plan, making him one of the world's highest-paid CEOs.

140,000
THE NUMBER of tickets *Dhurandhar 2* sold in under 24 hours of opening advance bookings, generating about ₹8.83 crore for premiere day shows across India.

114
THE NUMBER of billionaires worldwide now linked to AI companies, according to the Hurun Global Rich List 2026, with 46 of them joining the list for the first time.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

Nari Shakti driving India's progress: Modi

Achievements of India's Nari Shakti are a source of pride, PM Narendra Modi said. PTI

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday conveyed greetings to all women on the occasion of International Women's Day, and said the achievements of India's 'Nari Shakti' are a source of pride. He said empowerment of women is at the core of his government's various schemes and initiatives and it remains committed to creating opportunities that enable every woman to realise her full potential and contribute to India's journey of development.

"On International Women's Day, I extend my greetings to all our Nari Shakti. Across every field, women are shaping India's progress with determination, creativity and unmatched zeal. Their achievements inspire our nation and strengthen our collective resolve to build a Viksit Bharat," he said in a message.

Modi said as India progresses further, the aspirations and contributions of women will continue to guide the country's collective journey towards a strong and prosperous nation. "The achievements of India's Nari Shakti are a source of pride and a powerful reminder of the transformative role in nation building," he added. PTI

Nitish Kumar's son Nishant joins JD(U)

Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar's son Nishant Kumar joined the JD(U) on Sunday and said he would work to strengthen the party's organisation.

Nishant, an engineering graduate who is in his 40s, was inducted into the party at its headquarters here in the presence of top leaders, including Union minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh 'Lalan' and JD(U)'s national working president Sanjay Jha.

After joining the party, Nishant, clad in a *kurta-pyjama* and wearing flip-flops, said, "My father decided to go to the Rajya Sabha. It was his personal decision. We all respect it. We will keep working under his guidance. I will work to strengthen the organisation." PTI

Iraq oil output plunges about 60%

Iraq's oil production has collapsed by about 60% as the Iran war means there aren't enough tankers to load the nation's crude.

The country is now pumping about 1.7 million to 1.8 million barrels of oil every day, down from about 4.3 million a day before the conflict began, according to people with knowledge of the matter, who asked not to be identified because the output levels aren't public.

Iraq was the first major gulf producing country to have to cut output because of the conflict, a step that has since been followed by the UAE and Kuwait. The war has effectively closed the Strait of Hormuz, meaning an ever-dwindling number of tankers to export the region's barrels. BLOOMBERG

Prices on the LME climbed more than 4% on Friday, extending this week's advance to about 9.7%. REUTERS

Aluminium records biggest weekly gain

Aluminium recorded its biggest weekly gain since 2023 after the deepening conflict in West Asia snarled shipments from the region and left traders bracing for more disruptions. Prices on the London Metal Exchange (LME) climbed more than 4% on Friday, extending this week's advance to about 9.7%. Earlier in the week, the benchmark contract spiked to levels last seen in 2022.

Now in the seventh day, the US-Israeli attacks on Iran — and Tehran's response — have sent shock waves through the global aluminium industry. Metal flows through the strategic Strait of Hormuz are effectively halted, and smelters in the Persian Gulf region have reported disruptions to deliveries and production this week. The so-called US Midwest premium, the amount added to LME prices to deliver aluminium to that region, rose to a fresh high of $1.075 a pound Friday, according to Fastmarkets Ltd. European premiums also surged this week. The Chinese aluminium industry, the world's biggest, is considering how to respond to prolonged disruptions. China has potential to plug emerging supply gaps, especially if global output of semi-fabricated aluminium gets hit. BLOOMBERG

PTI

Nepal's rapper-led centrist party set for landslide win

Balendra Shah defeats 4-time PM Oli in first elections since 2025 anti-corruption protests

AFP
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KATHMANDU

Nepal's centrist RSP party of rapper-turned-politician Balendra Shah had secured a majority in the direct parliamentary elections, partial official results showed on Sunday, and was heading for a landslide according to official trends.

The 35-year-old's Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP) was also leading in the proportional representation vote, according to results declared and election commission trends.

The vote was the first since deadly September 2025 youth anti-corruption protests toppled the government.

Shah himself had on Saturday defeated the veteran four-time prime minister K.P. Sharma Oli—whose Marxist-led government was ousted in the violence last year — in his own seat.

His victory over the 74-year-old Oli, and his rise from the capital's mayor to potential prime minister, marks one of the most dramatic results in recent Nepali politics.

The September 2025 youth-led demonstrations, under a loose Gen Z banner, began over a brief social media ban but quickly tapped into broader grievances over corruption and a struggling economy.

Elections on Thursday chose a new 275-member House of Representatives, the lower house of parliament, with 185 seats chosen directly, and 110 by a proportional representation vote.

Poll monitors, The Asian Network for Free Elections, said Sunday that voting had been "peaceful and orderly and reflected continued public engagement with democratic processes despite recent political instability". On Sunday afternoon, 153 of the direct elections had been declared: RSP dominating with 117, Nepali Congress 17, and the Marxists of now-defeated Oli trailing with seven.

Former Maoist guerrilla commander Pushpa Kamal Dahal, a three-time prime minister, won his seat, with his party holding seven in total.

Trends showed Shah's RSP was also leading in eight of the remaining 12 constituencies in the direct elections.

In the proportional representation vote, RSP was leading with nearly half of the counted votes—but final results could take several more days.

West Asia tensions to hit steel markets

The global steel industry, including India, is expected to face multiple market-related issues in the coming days as the escalating crisis in the Middle East impacts fuels cost that has lead to increased freight rates, according to BigMint Research.

Military tensions in the region are increasing as both Iran, and the US, along with Israel, continue to attack each other.

BigMint analysts said crude oil, LNG, and freight costs are rising simultaneously, transmitting cost pressure directly into steel and steel-related commodity markets.

From an average of $70 a barrel before the war, crude oil prices have risen to about $90/per barrel, an analyst said, adding that the cost is expected to continue to rise in the coming days.

War has also impacted freight cost, which jumped almost 40% in recent times. PTI

The prolonged conflict could cause significant damage to the global economy, analysts said. AFP

'Prolonged war may hit fertilizers'

India currently has sufficient availability of fertilizers, but prolonged conflict in West Asia could pose problems, said a top official of Fertilisers and Chemicals Travancore Limited (FACT), the largest supplier to South Indian states.

FACT, a public sector company, relies on raw materials such as rock phosphate and phosphoric acid exported from several countries in West Asia and the Middle East, and they are brought via the sea route.

The prolonged conflict could cause significant damage to the global economy, according to analysts.

Currently, there is no harvest season in India; it will begin after July, the Kochi-headquartered FACT's managing director S. Sakthimani said, when asked about the potential impact of the current global situation on fertiliser production in the country. PTI

Jaquar eyes scaling lighting biz revenue

Bathroom and lighting solutions provider Jaquar Group is targeting to scale its lighting business revenue to ₹1,700 crore in the next three years, according to a senior company official.

The company, which has a portfolio that includes LED, commercial, outdoor, architectural and facade lighting, besides consumer lighting such as bulbs and tube lights, plans to expand its outdoor and landscape portfolio, along with architectural indoor lighting.

"Over the next three years, we aim to scale the lighting business to ₹1,600 crore to ₹1,700 crore in revenue," Jaquar Group director-Lighting, Ranbir Mehra said. He was responding to a query on the growth prospects of the lighting business of the Jaquar Group.

Jaquar Lighting contributes 8-10% to Jaquar Group's overall revenue, said Mehra. PTI

Euler calls to ease auto PLI norms

There is a need to relax criteria for India's PLI scheme for automobiles to enable electric vehicle startups to benefit and contribute to the country's green mobility journey, according to Euler Motors founder and CEO Saurav Kumar. The high ceiling for revenue and investments outlined in the auto PLI scheme has meant that a company such as Euler Motors has not been able to participate in the scheme, Kumar told *PTI* in an interview. Eligibility criteria under auto PLI scheme says that an OEM must have a minimum global group revenue of ₹10,000 crore and invest in fixed assets worth ₹3,000 crore.

"That unfortunately did not incentivize startups like us who are equally investing in this space and pushing the technology and R&D at the forefront," he said. In terms of products, Euler Motors has both electric four-wheeler and three-wheeler commercial cargo vehicles, which are covered under the PLI scheme, Kumar added. PTI

Auto component makers take the safe lane on green journey

FROM PAGE 1

because we have enough content there in terms of emissions, after-treatment systems, etc," Chandra said.

"If it swings the other way to electrification, great, because we can sell a lot more very expensive shock absorbers because these have to be electronically controlled," he said, adding that hybrids will give the best of both worlds to the company's business. Listed in November, Tenneco Clean Air is the subsidiary of American component major Tenneco Inc. It has a market cap of over ₹22,000 crore.

Satpute of Greaves added that the company, which has a market capitalization of ₹3,580 crore, has also got access to products like gear shift systems, foot throttle controls, steering wheels and park brake cable, among others, which will be required across all powertrains.

The commentary from Greaves and Tenneco comes as some global automakers write off their EV investments and pivot towards hybrids.

In December, Ford Motor said it expects to write down $19.5 billion EV investments. In February, Stellantis said it is taking a $26.5 billion write-off from its electrification investments. The announcements come months after Germany-based Porsche announced a delay in the rollout of its EV lineup in September, which will cost its parent, Volkswagen, about $6 billion.

The clean fuel transition will be a phased affair. ISTOCKPHOTO

Pune-based Belrise Industries, which is looking to expand its business in the four-wheeler space, is taking note, stating most of the business it has currently comes from powertrain-agnostic products.

"If you see the bread and butter of what Belrise does, there's chassis, polymer parts, suspensions—all of those are power-agnostic. So, in effect, whether it's an EV or an ICE, our components go into both EVs as well as ICE," said Swastid Badve, general manager, Belrise Industries. Belrise was listed in May last year, and is currently worth ₹17,540 crore.

A top Indian government panel set up by Niti Aayog said in a 10 February report that the clean fuel transition will be a phased affair, including multiple technologies like hybrids, flex fuels and CNG.

Domain experts argue that a flexible approach has become essential for auto component makers at a time when it remains unclear which technology will hold prominence in the next three to five years.

"Instead of making a binary bet on EV only components, many suppliers are investing in components and engineering capabilities that can serve ICE, hybrid and electric platforms simultaneously," Harshvardhan Sharma, Group Head of Automotive Technology & Innovation at Nomura Research Institute Consulting & Solutions India, said.

"The transition to electrification will not be linear, particularly in markets like India where ICE, hybrid and EV technologies will coexist," Sharma said. "In that environment, suppliers that are powertrain agnostic with products spanning multiple propulsion architectures are structurally better positioned to manage both demand uncertainty and technology risk," he added.

Sembcorp, Hexa circle Enel India renewable business for $300 mn

FROM PAGE 1

20.4GW across 11 countries, with India accounting for 7.6GW.

Also last year, Hexa Climate Solutions acquired Finnish state-run energy power utility Fortum Oyj's renewable energy platform Fortum India Pvt Ltd (FIPL) along with its management company and carbon credit portfolio.

On its part, Hexa's backer I Squared Capital plans to invest around $500 million in the company that has a focus on renewable energy, water and carbon offsets, and has a 2.5GW development pipeline.

Spokespersons for Enel Group and HSBC, as well as Hexa Climate Solutions' founder and executive chairman Sanjeev Aggarwal declined to comment. Queries emailed to Sembcorp Industries Ltd on Thursday evening remained unanswered till press time.

Tough times

This comes at a time when India's green energy sector is facing several challenges. These include curtailment of renewable power in Rajasthan and Gujarat, two of the country's largest renewable-producing states; discoms selling renewable power on exchanges at prices below procurement cost; and states such as Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Assam and West Bengal signing costlier coal-based power purchase agreements (PPAs) instead of cheaper green power.

Several renewable energy deals are currently underway. ISTOCKPHOTO

In addition, 43GW of renewable capacity involving investments of ₹2.1 trillion currently lacks PPAs or power supply agreements (PSAs).

However, analysts say India's commercial and industrial (C&I) segment continues to attract strong investor interest and is expected to grow exponentially.

"The commercial and industrial segment is expected to see renewable energy (RE) capacity rise to 57GW by fiscal 2028, from 40GW expected by the end of fiscal 2026," Crisil Ratings said in a 26 February statement.

Crisil noted that the capacity addition will be driven by five factors—favourable long-term PPA tariffs vis-à-vis on-grid tariff, net-zero targets, renewable purchase obligations (RPOs) for corporates, as well as attractive returns and strong counterparty profiles for developers.

"C&I capacity additions will be mostly undertaken by developers backed by private equity players, spurred by better return on equity of C&I projects vis-à-vis utility-scale projects on account of higher tariffs. This will be underpinned by the presence of counterparties with strong credit profiles, ensuring stable cash flow generation," the statement added.

Expanding dealscape

India currently has a renewable energy capacity of 258GW, of which solar accounts for 135.80GW, and wind, 54.51GW. With the government setting a target to auction 50GW of renewable power annually, the pace of capacity addition has picked up significantly.

Several renewable energy deals are currently underway in India, as reported by Mint. These include alternative investment firm Stonepeak seeking up to a 15% stake in AM Green's holding company in a potential deal having an equity value of around $1.4 billion.

Separately, Welspun World has tasked EY to sell a majority stake in its green energy platform at an equity value of around $100 million. In another proposed transaction, IFC, Siemens AG and Fullerton Fund Management plan to acquire a 49% stake in green hydrogen manufacturer Hygenco Green Energies Pvt. Ltd.

WHY INSTAMART IS PLAYING NOICE

The q-commerce outfit is trying to become an FMCG company inside a delivery app with its new F&B private label

Sowmya Ramasubramanian &
Samiksha Goel

BENGALURU

In a market where delivery speeds are converging and discounting is costly, private labels are emerging as one of the few structural levers left to improve margins.

MINT

Recently, Anupama, a 28-year-old lawyer in Bengaluru, was scrolling through quick commerce (q-commerce) company Swiggy Instamart's app when a thumbnail of a packet of banana chips caught her eye. The brand, Noice, was priced slightly higher than some of the other options on the screen, including national labels she had grown up with.

"It didn't look like a typical grocery brand at all. It felt more like something you'd pick up at a boutique food store," Anupama told *Mint*. Price was not a factor but the presentation on the screen definitely was. Like a moth to a light, the bright yellow colour drew her in and she tapped on it.

That instinctive and irrational add-to-cart moment is exactly what Swiggy is betting Noice can engineer on a large scale.

When the company rolled out the food and beverage (F&B) brand in the middle of last year, it did not resemble a routine back-end grocery experiment. The packs were hard to miss—splashed in bold colours that stood out on the app's grid of thumbnails, they quickly caught everyone's attention.

This was not your typical *atta* and rice. Under Noice, Instamart has launched a wide range of items, including regional snacks, frozen favourites, protein-rich products, and impulse buys such as lime soda and premium dark chocolate.

Simply put, this is Instamart trying to become a fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) company inside a delivery app.

In a business where margins are thin and competition is intense, Noice could become the company's most strategic lever to improve unit economics. Or it could end up as a failed bet.

A DIFFERENT PLAYBOOK

Private labels are not new to quick commerce. Zepto has Relish for meat and seafood, and Daily Good for staples. Blinkit runs Wholefarm while the Tata group-owned BigBasket has BB Royal, BB Popular and Fresho. Swiggy Instamart has Supreme Harvest in staples.

Nearly 40% of BigBasket's revenue comes from private brands, pushing the platform's repeat usage to 50%, *Mint* reported last year.

Early experiments were largely anchored in staples and industry experts say this was by design. Categories such as dal, rice and sugar are commodity purchases with limited brand loyalty. Quality is easier to benchmark and supply chains are easier to control.

Private labels in these categories typically won on price. Across q-commerce and e-commerce, the in-house brand was positioned as a cheaper alternative to national brands listed on the same platform. The thesis was operational efficiency and cost control, not brand building. Even when Blinkit (formerly Grofers) expanded into multiple packaged categories, the core differentiator remained affordability.

Instamart's Noice, however, appears to have taken a different path. Instead of focusing on staples it spans over 300 stock-keeping units (SKUs), including bread, *paneer*, pickles, chips, *kombucha*, regional sweet treats and *dosa* batter. Instead of affordability, it looks at premium pricing. For instance, a 100gm packet of Noice's banana chips costs ₹59. In comparison, a 100gm pack of Chheda's banana chips costs ₹32 and Modern Kitchens' ₹43.

Industry watchers say this is less a sourcing play and more an attempt to build a consumer-facing FMCG brand within quick commerce. The focus is on discovery, snacking and trend-driven categories with packaging, branding and fast iteration cycles that make it resemble a typical direct-to-consumer (D2C) playbook rather than a grocery margin optimization strategy.

Moreover, the broader strategy, according to a former Swiggy executive who looked at supply partnerships, was to position Noice as a 'better-for-you' alternative. That meant avoiding palm oil, limiting heavy mechanization and working with semi-local vendors capable of small-batch production at scale.

In some ways, Noice's approach mirrors the playbook of Trader Joe's, the US-based retailer that built a deeply loyal customer base on the back of private labels. Trader Joe's treats its in-house products as the main event, not as cheaper substitutes, investing in distinctive packaging and a tightly curated assortment that makes discovery central to the shopping experience.

"By controlling sourcing, pricing and storytelling, it builds loyalty to its own labels. Noice appears to be attempting a similar shift in quick commerce, positioning its private label as a destination rather than just a margin lever," said Ankur Bisen, senior partner at management consultancy firm The Knowledge Company.

Swiggy Instamart did not respond to *Mint*'s queries.

> Noice's approach mirrors that of US-based retailer Trader Joe's, which built a loyal customer base treating its in-house labels as the main event, not as substitutes.

PACKAGING WINS

For a brand that is discovered first as a small thumbnail on a 6-inch phone screen, packaging is a critical lever to attract attention and drive trials. Noice's packs lean heavily into bold, bright colours with "Noice" splashed across the front in a large, unmissable font, designed to stand out instantly on a crowded app grid.

"In quick commerce, your first shelf is a phone screen, not a supermarket aisle. Your pack has to stand out as a tiny square, stay readable and still look different from every big legacy brand sitting next to it," Bisen said.

In categories where price is not the only differentiator, packaging becomes central to recall and repeat purchase, the real driver of private-label success.

There are enough examples in traditional FMCG of packaging making a real dent in consumer mindshare. When Parle Agro moved its flagship mango-based drink Frooti from glass bottles to tetra packs two decades ago, it reshaped how consumers consumed the drink by aligning it with the on-the-go lifestyle.

A thicker laminate, matte finish and bold typography signal quality cues that can justify premium pricing in certain categories.

DATA IS KING

At the heart of Noice's strategy is something far more granular than traditional FMCG market research. It is consumption data. According to Sreedhar Prasad, former partner at KPMG and a startup advisor, quick commerce platforms are sitting on insights that legacy snack companies simply never had access to.

"I may purchase chicken, milk or *toor* dal, but there is no intelligence on that. It only tells you frequency and basic patterns," he said. Staples reveal habits, but not the nuance that snacking shows.

When a *makhana*-based snack sees traction among South Indian consumers, or a *murukku* repeatedly goes out of stock in a particular cluster, that signals something deeper. "That knowledge was never easy to get before," Prasad said. The same applies to jaggery banana chips popular in Kerala or *karam gavvalu*, an Andhra snack. "Which cluster has a population that orders this frequently? Large FMCG brands have not had hyperlocal consumption knowledge."

For Instamart's Noice, this hyperlocal, contextual understanding of snacking behaviour is the edge. That edge has not gone unnoticed by large consumer companies and the dynamics are shifting.

According to Rakesh Raghuvanshi, founder and chief executive officer (CEO) of Sekel Tech, a technology company that helps legacy consumer brands improve their digital presence, as FMCG companies make note of the growing popularity of private brands, they are recalibrating their strategy, allocating higher spends towards better visibility on marketplaces, especially quick commerce.

"Quick commerce is no longer an experimental channel for large brands," Raghuvanshi said. "They are treating it as a primary shelf. That means higher investments in ads, search optimization and sharper pricing because that's where high-intent consumption is shifting."

Private labels are driving this strategy shift.

THE PROFITABILITY LEVER

Noice's rapid scale-up comes at a time when the quick commerce pecking order is shifting. Eternal-owned Blinkit led the market by value with nearly 47% share, followed by Zepto with 24%, Instamart at 22% and others at 6%, according to calendar year 2025 data from research firm Datum Intelligence.

In the December quarter, Blinkit fulfilled 243.3 million orders while Instamart serviced less than half that number—about 106.4 million orders. Order volume data for Zepto, BigBasket, Flipkart Minutes and Amazon Now is not available.

The adjusted Ebitda loss of Instamart widened to ₹908 crore in the December quarter, from ₹578 crore in the year-ago period, according to the company's disclosures. Ebitda is short for earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortization.

This indicates how scale alone is no longer a sufficient moat in a market where delivery speeds are converging and discounting is costly. Private labels are emerging as one of the few structural levers left to improve margins and create reasons for repeat usage.

The Knowledge Company's Bisen believes that as competition intensifies, differentiation will also matter. "Everyone can promise 10-minute delivery. But only a differentiated portfolio will stand out," he said.

High-frequency snacking categories pull users back onto the app, expand basket sizes and lift revenue per user. Private labels, with their higher margins and tighter supply control, strengthen unit economics.

By formalizing and branding regionally popular but largely unorganized products such as *chikki*, Mysore *pak* and *chakli*, Swiggy Instamart is creating pricing power in categories that previously lacked a clear benchmark.

"While not everything in Noice's portfolio may be new, many of the products being launched may not have had a strong national brand presence earlier. Further, when you are branding the unbranded, you dictate the price," said KPMG's Prasad.

Take something like jaggery-dipped banana chips from Kerala. "If I ask you how much 100gm should cost, you may not have an answer. There is no benchmark from large organized brands," Prasad added.

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THE RISKS

Private labels have always had inherent tension. The platform is both referee and player, hosting brands while competing with them. Quick commerce insiders recall how, in the early days, the balance of power was heavily tilted towards large FMCG companies and they had leverage in negotiations and even pushed back against competing private labels. Now, the platforms have become

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mint SHORT STORY

WHAT

Moving away from the approach taken by its rivals, Instamart is aiming to build a premium FMCG food and beverage brand within its delivery app ecosystem.

WHY

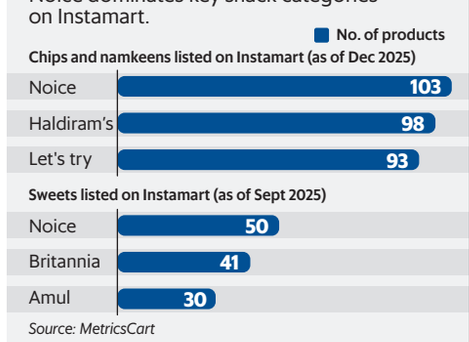
The move is likely aimed at improving the company's unit economics by focusing on premium pricing, packaging, semi-local sourcing, health and granular data to tailor products.

BUT

Making private labels visible while also meeting brand monetization commitments is a delicate exercise as q-commerce platforms earn significant advertising revenue from external brands.

Snack attack

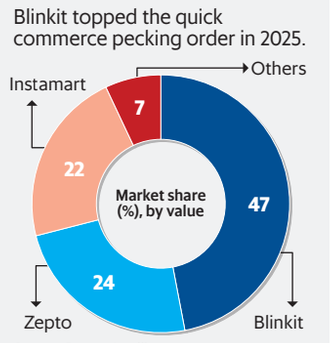
Noice dominates key snack categories on Instamart.



Source: MetricsCart

The war in the cart

Blinkit topped the quick commerce pecking order in 2025.



Source: Datum Intelligence

Revenue dash

While Instamart's revenue has surged, its losses have deepened.

Instamart's adjusted revenue and Ebitda (in ₹ crore)

Quarter	Revenue	Ebitda
Q3 FY25	603	-578
Q4 FY25	733	-840
Q1 FY26	859	-896
Q2 FY26	1,038	-849
Q3 FY26	1,052	-908

Adjusted revenue is operational income generated by the platform from orders and brand monetization; adjusted Ebitda is operating profit/loss from running Instamart before non-cash and financing items.

Source: Swiggy Ltd's quarterly financial statements

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SATISH KUMAR/MINT

Women's property rights: The law, the barriers—and the way forward

Women continue to face significant resistance from families when claiming inheritance, despite legal equality

Shefali Anand
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Owning property is a big step toward financial independence for women. It provides status in society and an economic foundation. "It is security for life, and it's their right," Gautam Khurana, managing partner and founder, India Law Offices LLP in Delhi, said.

However, land ownership by women in India remains abysmal. Only 18.7% of women between the ages 15 and 49 own a house by themselves, while 13.7% own it jointly with someone else, according to World Bank data.

Historically, daughters are often excluded from property distribution after a father's death. "The brother doesn't have to ask; the sister has to ask. And when she asks, she is considered bad," said Amita Jadhav, at Coro India, a non-profit organization that works for women empowerment in the marginalised segment. "We want to create an environment where women don't have to ask," she said.

This Women's Day, we explore the inheritance and property succession rights of women in India, and how to exercise them.

These rights are governed by personal religious laws and vary by faith. Here we focus on the Hindu Succession Act, 1956, applicable to Hindus, Buddhists, Jains and Sikhs.

Right to Parental Property

If a father leaves a valid will, its contents determine how his property will be distributed. However, if a Hindu man dies 'intestate', that is, without making a will, all his Class 1 legal heirs are entitled to an equal share in his property. These include the man's mother, wife and children—including daughters—regardless of whether they are married, unmarried, divorced or widowed.

Daughters have been allowed equal rights in their father's property only after the Hindu Succession Act was amended in 2005. A daughter has the same claim as a son in the father's property, including the family home, even if the father lived with the son and the son continues to occupy the property after the father's death. Daughters also have an equal share in any ancestral property, passed down through generations.

In practice, however, women often face resistance from brothers or other relatives who believe daughters should not claim a share. "Even in the educated class, nobody gives," said Usha Tiwari, founder of Usha Tiwari & Associates, a law firm in Mumbai.

Often, the woman is asked to sign a document by which she willingly gives up her share of the property in favour of the brother or other heirs, Legally, this is known as a 'release' or 'relinquishment' deed.

Right to husband's property

In case a husband dies intestate, the wife can claim an equal share in any land or house he had purchased and registered in his name. She would have to share this with the husband's other Class 1 heirs, including his mother and children.

However, if the husband's property is part of his family's ancestral assets, the allocation changes. In that case, the wife can claim only a part of the husband's share in the ancestral property.

How to claim share in property

Properties are broadly classified into two types: movable assets such as bank fixed deposits, mutual funds and shares, insurance policies, and provident fund, etc., and immovable property, which typically includes land or a home.

To claim her share of these assets, a woman first needs to obtain a legal heir document that would establish her right to ownership. "It's important to establish the family tree," said Khurana.

One such document is a legal heir certificate, also called an heirship or survivor certificate, which establishes the relationship between the deceased and the heirs. This is typically issued by the local revenue office, such as the sub-divisional magistrate's office or a tahsildar. If there is no dispute, it can be obtained within a month, said Praveen Nagar, founder, PS Legal Advocates & Consultants, a law firm in Delhi.

> A will or family settlement deed can help prevent inheritance disputes and ensure fair distribution

Another document that may be required is a succession certificate, issued by a civil court where the property is located. The judge verifies and establishes the list of assets and the ownership of the claimant to the property or assets. The process can take about six months if the matter is non-contentious, said Nagar.

One or both of these certificates may be required by the bank or a company where fixed deposits or other financial assets are kept, along with other documents and fees. If a nominee has been named on the financial asset, the proceeds are typically transferred to the nominee unless it can be proved that the nomination was not valid. "It's always good to have a nominee in the bank account," said Nagar.

However, if a woman was not nominated and she feels that she has been left out of her fair share in the bank deposit or another financial asset, she can contest the issue in court, said Khurana.

Meanwhile, to get her share in a physical property like a home, the woman, along with the other heirs, must get the property registered in their names. This is done typically at the sub-registrar's office, where property documents are held. They'll need to submit the original title deed of the property, the succession certificate etc, along with various fees.

Once the registration is done, the next step is to get a property 'mutation' done. This is a process to put your name as an owner or co-owner in the records of the local municipal corporation or land revenue department. By updating this record, you become liable to pay property tax, and other bills associated with the property.

If the residential unit in question is part of a housing society, you would also need to change the owner's name in the society's office. They may ask for a heirship or succession certificate, and a no-objection certificate from other heirs.

Dispute and Prevention

If the other heirs, such as the brothers, are unwilling to give the woman her due share, she will need to file a lawsuit for partition.

This is a years-long process, especially if the brother is living on the disputed property or has money to keep delaying court hearings. It also takes a toll on the woman's mental health and standing in the family, said Tiwari. "She has to choose — does she want the relationship or the property," said Tiwari.

Even if the court order comes in favour of the woman, and she is issued what is called a property inheritance decree, "to execute it, you will have to sweat it out," said Tiwari.

As much as possible, legal experts suggest resolving disputes outside court. Ideally, start the groundwork early even before the event of a succession comes up. The first step is to understand what are the assets involved, who has their ownership, and your legal rights.

Next, ask your father or husband to put in writing how he wants to dispose of his assets. "It's always good to have a will," said Nagar.

"If there is no will, the best solution is a family settlement agreement," said Khurana. This is a simple agreement in which all heirs agree on who gets what, and put it in writing in front of a witness. This agreement can be made even prior to losing the parent, he said. "That's very good insurance against disputes later on," he said.

Woman's property succession

The Hindu Succession Act takes a more tangled approach to who gets a woman's property if she dies without making a will.

If it's a property she purchased and owned, the first right to it goes to her children and her husband, and after that to the husband's heirs, which would include her mother-in-law. If the woman wants her parents to get a piece of her property, she would need to make a will.

For property inherited from her father, the succession will pass to the father's other heirs. Property inherited from the husband will pass to the husband's heirs.

A lack of awareness and societal norms have historically kept women in India away from claiming their right to property. "Law is one thing, but the practice is happening differently," said Jadhav. At Coro India they train leaders to help women get these rights and reclaim their power. "Getting the property is to shake that system," she said.

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Her right to inherit

A 2005 amendment to the Hindu Succession Act puts women on a par with men in property inheritance.

What women are entitled to

- **An equal share in her father's property**, along with other Class I heirs—brothers, sisters, mother and grandmother.
- **An equal share in her husband's property**, along with his other Class I heirs—children and mother.

How to secure your share

- **Obtain a heirship or survivor certificate** to establish that you are one of the legal heirs.
- **Obtain a succession certificate** to claim and transfer inherited property in your name.
- **Get your name recorded** in government property records as owner or co-owner.
- **If the property is in a housing society,** apply to update its records to reflect your ownership or co-ownership.

Risks to watch out for

- Family pressure to sign a relinquishment or release deed, which gives up your property rights.
- Lengthy legal disputes, which can take years to resolve and enforce.

Plan ahead

- Have a clear discussion with your father or husband on how property should be distributed after their death.
- Encourage them to write a will.
- Consider a family settlement agreement, where all family members agree on how property and assets will be divided.

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POWER POINT

MRIN AGARWAL

We welcome your views and comments at
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WOMEN INVESTORS: QUESTION THE TIP BEFORE YOU TRUST

For Vrinda, 36, her go-to for financial advice was a group of colleagues known to be smart investors. Once a strong advocate of them, she now cautions others against such groups.

Like many women, Vrinda had never learnt about money management and kept out of financial conversations at home, with her partner preferring to keep family finances under his control. Constant investment chatter at work eventually prompted her to start investing. The group was investing in cryptocurrencies at the time. Unfortunately, the platform through which she invested suffered a hacking incident and she lost her capital.

Burnt by the experience, she stayed away for a while, only to return to investing through high-yield corporate bonds last year. Only after hearing about a recent corporate bond default did she research further and understand the risks. Vrinda's story is not unusual. Many women quietly navigate similar financial challenges, often relying on familiar circles for financial advice due to lack of knowledge and trusted sources to check queries.

Online communities offer easy access to information, but are filled with unverified opinions and trend-driven recommendations—not advice tailored to individual needs. For instance, offering small discounts on services, or encouraging ₹10-a-day savings plan won't help create long-term wealth. Experience with phone groups is poor—many lack verification and transparency, often operating like Ponzi schemes. Social media is filled with 1-2 minute content, mostly tips—not long-term wealth-building advice.

Women often fall prey to promises of high, guaranteed returns from ULIPs, corporate bonds, fractional property investments—or unregulated schemes like gold savings plans from jewellery shops or quick-return trading strategies. Much of this is driven by the urge to catch up, or prove they can generate good returns.

> Women should pause, verify sources, align investments with long-term financial goals

But investing rarely rewards haste or comparison. One must step back and approach decisions rationally—understand the product, assess the risks and align the investments with one's financial goals. Instead of reacting to noise or pressure, investors must pause, ask questions, verify the sources and rely only on sound financial principles.

Women can build smaller support circles with peers committed to learning and making informed decisions. Such circles can be spaces to discuss ideas, share resources and question investment opportunities before acting. Equally important is finding a credible financial advisor to work with the group. For years, many women have been accustomed to signing financial documents without fully understanding them, largely because they were not included in financial decision-making. This is especially true of loan documents, which can place legal liability on the woman as a co-borrower. Even in investments, women sometimes sign up for products without questioning if they align with their needs.

Take time to read, ask questions and fully understand financial documents. It should not be seen as a dreary task, but as a mandatory step in decision-making, as women are frequent targets of digital fraud due to low familiarity with financial products, digital platforms and fraud tactics. They become targets through several common channels that appear legitimate at first glance.

Unknown links via messages or social media promise investment opportunities, rewards or urgent updates. The other tactic involves messages promising instant loans or exclusive deals, prompting individuals to share sensitive information such as card details or OTPs. Scammers may also impersonate bank or regulatory officials, claiming to resolve an issue or update KYC details.

To stay safe from digital frauds, women can follow three simple mantras: avoid clicking unknown links or responding to suspicious calls; never share financial information; and limit public details. Vrinda's story shows the most powerful financial decision a woman can make is taking ownership of her choices. This Women's Day, move from merely signing to questioning.

Mrin Agarwal is a financial educator, and the founder of Finsafe India, and co-founder of Womantra.

How different assets are taxed?

This table shows the post Budget 2024 capital gains tax treatment across different assets. As a uniform rule, LTCG on all assets except debt funds is now 12.5%, and STCG on assets where STT is paid is 20%, while assets without STT continue to be taxed at slab rates.

	Holding period for LTCG	STCG tax rate	LTCG tax rate
Equity MFs, ETFs and stocks	>12 months	**20%**	**12.5%***
Gold ETFs	>12 months	Slab rate	**12.5%**
REITs/InVITs	>12 months	**20%**	**12.5%**
Listed bonds	>12 months	Slab rate	**12.5%**
Debt MFs**			
Bought before 1 April 2023	>24 months	Slab rate	**12.5%**
Bought 1 April 2023 onwards	NA	Slab rate	Slab rate
Gold MFs^, physical gold, overseas MFs, FOFs	>24 months	Slab rate	**12.5%**
Foreign equity, international ETFs	>24 months	Slab rate	**12.5%**
Real estate	>24 months	Slab rate	Bought after 23 July 2024: 12.5% Bought before 23 July 2024: lower of 12.5% without indexation and 20% with indexation

*On gains above ₹1.25 lakh. **includes funds that have invested over 65% of proceeds in debt and money market instruments.
MF: Mutual funds; ETFs: Exchange-traded funds; REITs: Real Estate Investment Trusts; InVITs: Infrastructure Investment Trusts; FOF: Fund of Funds; NA: Not Applicable. All rates are base; surcharge and cess extra. ^gold MFs that invest in an underlying gold ETF. Those without an FoF structure qualify as long-term asset after 1 year. Source: *Mint* Research

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

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Why Instamart is playing Noice

FROM PAGE 10

indispensable, even for large companies.

The power balance may have shifted, but the friction remains. Making private labels visible while also meeting brand monetization commitments is a delicate exercise, according to industry experts, as quick commerce platforms earn significant advertising revenue from external brands that pay for premium placement.

There are operational thumb rules to private labels. Industry observers say private labels work best in categories that are large and where a vendor's minimum order quantity can realistically be sold within 15 to 21 days. Anything slower raises the risk of expiry, working capital getting locked in inventory, and pressure on already-thin margins.

Small-batch manufacturing, which Noice leans into, reduces industrial-scale risk but increases the chances of stock-outs. Wastage, expiry and out-of-stock situations can quickly erode margins in a fast-delivery model.

Moreover, building an FMCG brand is capital intensive. Staples allow for packaging efficiency. A handful of generic pouches can work across dozens of SKUs—50gm of *jeera*, mustard or *methi* can sit in the same standardized pack design.

Noice's packs lean heavily into bold, bright colours.

FMCG snacking does not work that way. Experts note that products such as *bhujia*, chips or biscuits require distinct pouches, laminates and pack designs. Each category therefore needs separate tooling, packaging development and inventory planning. While the assortment may appear as a colourful grid of products on the app, it is backed by significant upfront investment in design, packaging and supply chain coordination.

But operational complexity is only part of the risk. The experience of Trader Joe's illustrates the sensitivities that can arise when a retailer builds a powerful private-label portfolio. The American retailer has faced social media and legal backlash after it introduced comparable products already sold by brands. This underlies the structural tension when a company operates as both marketplace and competitor.

There is yet another dimension. The dual role—neutral intermediary and competing seller—attracts scrutiny under Indian law, said Sonam Chandwani, managing partner at KS Legal & Associates, a law firm.

"Under the Consumer Protection (E-commerce) Rules, 2020, platforms must ensure transparency in seller identification, clear disclosures and fair grievance redressal. Beyond that, competition law becomes relevant. If a platform enjoys market power in online food delivery or discovery, any algorithmic self-preferencing, preferential visibility, differential commissions or access to seller data could be examined as abuse of dominance under the Competition Act, 2002," Chandwani said.

In the event of conflict, an aggrieved brand could approach the Competition Commission of India, seek contractual remedies or initiate civil proceedings, Chandwani noted.

There are challenges aplenty to navigate, but with Noice, Swiggy Instamart is looking to break out from the pack with its F&B private label, taking the premium path rather than rubbing shoulders with the rabble in the affordable aisles on its app. It may well succeed and spur others to do likewise. Or it could fall flat.

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OUR VIEW

ISTOCKPHOTO

Deploy municipal bonds to upgrade Indian cities

Urban local bodies could use these instruments to mobilize funds and modernize our cities. But we must strengthen the market for this paper first. Here are some measures that'll help

Urbanization and economic development. One mirrors the other. Urban India accounts for over 63% of GDP, with this share expected to rise to 75% by 2030, and more than 600 million people are projected to live in our cities by 2036. One would imagine urban quality of life and infrastructure are on top of policy minds. In the words of the 16th Finance Commission, "Cities concentrate resources, including physical and human capital, infrastructure and civil amenities, thereby fostering consumption, innovation and employment opportunities." But unless cities have proper mobility, water, sanitation, clean air, living spaces, amenities and governance, India's urban rush will only result in glorified slums. Urban Local Bodies (ULBs), which must create the ecosystem needed to nurture the orderly growth of these modern habitats, claim they lack the resources required to set up state-of-the-art infra. The truth is more nuanced. Most ULBs are reluctant to tap the most obvious sources of local revenue: property taxes and user charges. They prefer to depend on state or central transfers. This is where municipal bonds, or munis, come in. These are debt instruments issued by cities to fund day-to-day obligations and finance projects like educational, transit or sewerage systems.

Munis are not new to India. The first were issued by Bengaluru in 1997. But the market for these bonds has stayed lacklustre. Government programmes like the Atal Mission for Rejuvenation and Urban Transformation (Amrut) and Smart Cities Mission are yet to move the needle on munis. According to a September 2025 paper put out by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi), only 29 municipal corporations had issued bonds totalling ₹4,240.3 crore with tenors ranging from four to 10 years and interest rates in a range from 7.59% to 10.23%. Part of the reason is the low credibility of our ULBs. Given Sebi's 2015 guidelines, only munis with a credit rating of BBB and above from a top credit rating agency in India can be issued to the public. The underlying logic, to improve confidence in these instruments, cannot be faulted. The problem is that most ULBs are either unrated or below investment grade.

One way to improve muni offtake is to ensure they are backed by ring-fenced cash flows that are deposited into escrow accounts. These can then be supported by security mechanisms like debt service or sinking fund accounts and interest payment accounts. A structured 'waterfall' for prioritized debt servicing would enable bond issuances to get better credit ratings even when municipal finances are modest. Efforts by the ministry of housing and urban affairs to strengthen the ecosystem through incentives should also help. Under Amrut 2.0, for instance, ULBs can receive ₹13 crore per ₹100 crore raised (up to ₹26 crore) as grant support. For those seeking a second round, the bonds must qualify as 'green' under Sebi's framework for non-convertible securities and the funds raised should be used for climate-aligned sectors like water, sanitation, renewable energy and urban resilience. The opportunities are huge; as is the need for funds. While the market for munis is largely untapped, for institutional investors like pension funds and insurers looking to park long-term funds, they are an obvious answer. It is now for ULBs to turn to them and strike two birds with one stone: get much-needed funds and provide urban residents with sorely-needed infrastructure.

MY VIEW | THE INTERSECTION

Why India must not take sides in foreign wars in a fractured world

India has stakes across ruptures and should stay strategically aloof to secure its national interests

NITIN PAI
is co-founder and director of The Takshashila Institution, an independent centre for research and education in public policy.

As conflicts increase in a world of disorder, the path that best serves India's interests is one of non-involvement. The causes over which countries are fighting are complex but do not concern us. New Delhi does not have the leverage necessary to decisively influence war and peace far beyond our shores, whether it is over Ukraine, West Asia or East Asia.

Further, although it may tilt towards one side in any conflict, India has stakes on all sides. It is thus not in India's interests to take any side over the US-Israel war on Iran, the prolonged Russian war on Ukraine or possibly a Chinese invasion of Taiwan. Let them fight it out. The winners will have to deal with India anyway.

In a different world, at a different time, I have argued for New Delhi to support the American war in Afghanistan and Pakistan. After Russia invaded Ukraine, I called for New Delhi to side with the majority of its economic partners in opposition to Moscow. I have constantly irritated the strategic establishment in New Delhi for years by advocating for power projection and expeditionary capacity far beyond our immediate region.

The situation is vastly different now. While we must accelerate both our defensive and power projection capabilities, among others, by doubling our defence budget, there is little we can gain by involvement that we cannot by non-involvement. We do not have our dogs in most of the fights going on around the world.

Our policies then should aim for two things.

First, manage the consequences of international conflicts; and *second*, ensure that those conflicts do not approach our region and homeland. Neither aim is easy to achieve, but both are within the capacity of the Indian state and society.

The consequences of the West Asian war that affect us have to do with the security of our nationals, oil and gas supplies, trade and financial flows. India has evacuated large numbers of its nationals from war zones before and is both capable and alert to this task. A major evacuation this time will be a lot harder than previous ones, though. Even so, Indian armed forces along with the maritime and aviation industry can pull this off. The navy, equipped with air defence capabilities, might also have to be tasked with securing shipping lanes.

Energy security and risks to commercial shipping are more difficult problems to solve. US President Donald Trump has announced that America will absorb war risks by underwriting insurance for ships transiting the Strait of Hormuz, which Iran has blocked. If this turns into implementable policy, India will get some breathing room. If not, New Delhi should be prepared to exercise the Russian-oil option, braving threats of higher American tariffs.

Reasonable people in Washington cannot begrudge India's purchase of Russian hydrocarbons in response to the impact of a war that was started by the US. The diplomacy of managing consequences is always a balancing act. It doesn't have to be elegant. It just has to be effective enough until things change. Economic policy will have to deal with the outbreak and fallout of the Iran war.

The second task is to ensure that all foreign wars are fought far from our shores and borders. This has both an external and internal dimension. Externally, New Delhi should be firm that while it understands that countries have their own reasons to go to war, India and its immediate region are not in the fray. There might be commercial arrangements with respect to defence trade that will continue to be honoured, but countries should not expect Indian military support as they fight their wars. This won't endear us to our partners, but there is little room for romanticism in today's world.

The internal task will be to politically manage differences of opinion in a way that doesn't make us more vulnerable to external threats and weaken already frayed social harmony. Law enforcement authorities in states and in New Delhi should be aware that putting too strong a lid on dissenting opinions can raise risks. Indeed, allowing civil society groups to express their views on foreign policy, especially if it differs from the official line, is particularly useful when pursuing a policy of non-involvement.

As conflicts rage around the world, the answer to the question, 'Which side are you on?' should be 'Our own.' This means safeguarding the Indian republic by ensuring national unity and high economic growth as well as defence of our borders.

When things settle down in the fullness of time, the victors and survivors of foreign conflicts will need India one way or the other, regardless of their disposition towards the country before and during the war.

It is possible that some outcomes will be adverse for us, but we will have to deal with them just the same.

Tailpiece: As an *udasina* (neutral and detached), there are some things New Delhi should do publicly and others privately. Mixing the two up can be embarrassing at best and seriously damage our interests at worst.

10 YEARS AGO

mint
Govt blinks, rolls back tax on EPF
Budget sets stage for hike in tuition fees
Sharapova starts to count cost of failed drug test, likely ban

JUST A THOUGHT

You can bomb the world into pieces, but you can't bomb it into peace.

MICHAEL FRANTI

MY VIEW | MODERN TIMES

Artificial intelligence isn't funny and can't explain why

MANU JOSEPH

is a journalist, novelist, and the creator of the Netflix series, 'Decoupled'

Like most people, artificial intelligence (AI) is not funny. I check every week. For some time now, I have been asking ChatGPT, and later Claude too, to tell me something funny. They're terrible. I have tried providing a setup and context. I gave ChatGPT my thoughts about this column and asked it to frame a humorous observation. It said: "Why did the AI cross the road? To optimize the chicken." It is that bad. AI is better at word play than observations, particularly sarcasm, which is the second lowest form of humour, and puns, which are the lowest.

Unlike some human bores, AI knows it is not very funny. After all, it is a connoisseur of humour. Why, I ask AI, are you not funny?

The bots offer some reasons. For instance, their lack of "timing." But this is a glorified aspect of comedy—it belongs to the territory of acting, not writing. Many who are not funny at all can manage timing once they are told what to say, while every person who is genuinely funny automatically has it. It is just a delivery device. Also, it is not true that AI bots can't master timing. I have seen AI videos of infants performing stand-up and they get timing. Another reason that AI tools give is an obvious one: comedy comes from lived experience and they have not lived. As Claude said, it is like, "a technically perfect cover band that is hollow." It's flattering itself if it thinks it is technically perfect in comedy.

These explanations may not be wrong, but they don't get to the heart of the matter. Why AI isn't funny is also a theory on comedy itself.

Humour is a form of human excellence. Like many arts, it is art only when it actually works or is in a special form. And excellence is a minority condition. An unspoken truth of civilization is that it is created by very few people; most people are only consumers of civilization, exactly like AI, not creators. The problem with AI is that it cannot learn only from the masters. There would be an identifiable copyright problem. You can steal from all of the world, but not from only a few. Also, who is to decide who the masters are? In any case, that is simply not how it learns. It learns by ingesting enormous amounts of material, identifying patterns and recreating them. In other words, it learns to acquire a skill in the most useless way. It is an excellent consumer of comedy—it probably knows every funny thing ever said and can identify grades of humour. Yet it cannot create something humorous. In essence, AI has no talent. It is like a literary intellectual who has read every book but cannot write a good one himself.

But what is talent? In most arts, talent is intuition. I am not saying talent is only intuition, but that the most exciting aspect of it is intuition. And intuition is not a paranormal thing. It is, oddly, somewhat similar to AI—a human brain absorbs an enormous amount of material, perhaps not at the scale of AI but still vast, from which moments of epiphany strike. Talent does not emerge from the vastness of knowledge but despite it; it sees in the clutter and aura of authorized beliefs something that others cannot or do not. That is intuition. A lot of comic observation has the quality of epiphany, a truth that resides dormant in most people that suddenly springs to life through an arrangement of words.

AI does not realize that humour is a form of human excellence that's rare even among humans

The word 'observation' has confused many, including writers, who take it as a compliment on how well they 'see' the world. But observation in art is not the act of seeing, but of remembering, often corrupting the memory with personality. That corruption can be grave and beautiful, or just funny. Take this observation by Eduardo Galeano, "Fleas dream of buying themselves a dog, and nobodies dream of escaping poverty..." It is a beautiful lament, and its beauty is unaffected by the impossibility of fleas dreaming of purchasing a dog. It is grave, yet comedy comes from the same place as such thoughts. Take this observation: When Brahmins dance it is 'culture,' when Dalits dance it is 'folk.' Galeano's lament on 'nobodies' takes a similar view. Humour is often a grave observation, just put differently. AI might be able to mimic Galeano's lament by winging poetic melodrama, which it does well, but it cannot make a funny observation on the subject, or any subject.

I asked AI why it is so bad at imitating even writers who, in my view, are easy to imitate—like P.G. Wodehouse, even though he is one of those sunny aristocrats whom eggheads in England call 'inimitable.' Generations of writers have tried to write like him and somewhat succeeded, too. I would have thought his unique voice would make him easy to replicate. He isn't. When I asked, AI admitted that even when asked to imitate only Wodehouse, it draws from a vast undifferentiated pool of writers. The result is a travesty. Asked whether copyright was the reason it could not learn only from Wodehouse's collected works, it gave a nebulous yes, with other technical reasons folded in.

There is another reason why AI isn't funny. Besides never seeing the lived lives of funny people, it never sees their failed drafts—the discarded versions from which the final comedy emerges.

AI is also confounded by luck. What it consumes is biased towards a very human phenomenon—art is mostly created by the lucky, those with social contacts, those who succeeded through circumstance, those who were simply in the right place. Most artists are mediocre and would not have succeeded without random luck. Success is riddled with the randomness, and AI is consuming the output of that randomness and trying to find patterns within it.

So it may take a long time. Or may never be funny.

GUEST VIEW

US-Israeli attack on Iran: When is an illegal war morally alright?

Armed aggression that violates international law could still claim legitimacy but this war doesn't meet the conditions for it

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AFP

In international relations, manifestly illegal government action can sometimes be morally defensible. While historical examples of legitimacy trumping legality are few and far between, they do exist. The question of whether the joint US-Israeli war on Iran is one such case demands more attention than it has received so far.

It should be beyond dispute that the initiation of this war by US President Donald Trump and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu flagrantly violated international law, even if many of their allies have shown a willingness to fudge this issue. Iran did not pose a threat to either country—from nuclear weapons, conventional missiles or state-sponsored terrorism—of an imminence or on a scale that could possibly justify, in the absence of the United Nations Security Council's approval, preemptive military action as a form of self-defence. The US and Israel acted when they did not because of Iran's strength, but because of its relative weakness.

The attack is just the latest in a series of actions by the world's most powerful countries—including Russia's invasion of Ukraine, China's militarization of the South China Sea and America's seizure of Venezuelan President Nicolás Maduro—that disdain international law. The collapse of whatever is left of the rules-based order is bad news for the rest of the world. It demands concerted pushback from capable middle powers, as Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney compellingly argued in his landmark Davos speech in January.

Nonetheless, can one still argue that, whatever the law, the monstrous crimes of Iran's theocratic leadership justify its military decapitation? The charge sheet against the regime, both at home and abroad, is long and ugly, culminating in the slaughter of tens of thousands of peacefully protesting citizens earlier this year—an atrocity comparable in intensity to those committed in Rwanda and the Balkans in the 1990s, and more recently in Myanmar and Sudan.

The joyful celebrations in Iranian streets and among diaspora communities following the news that Iran's supreme leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei had been killed tell a compelling story. This is a war, at least in its initial stages, more welcomed than feared by a sizable mass—perhaps even the majority—of Iran's citizens.

We have been here before. Perhaps the most memorable legality-versus-legitimacy argument came with Nato's military intervention—which lacked authorization from the UN Security Council—to prevent the ethnic cleansing and massacre of Kosovo Albanians in 1999. Most of the world saw that air campaign as morally, if not legally, defensible, wholly motivated by genuine concern for the protection of civilians, both proportional and effective in its execution, and doing more good than harm.

If the Iran war is to be defended on moral grounds, the conditions that convinced in the Kosovo case must be satisfied here as well. On the evidence, that seems like a hard ask. As for motivation, only the most gullible of observers could believe that the actions of Trump and Netanyahu were motivated by a passion for human rights and democracy.

Netanyahu has only ever been concerned with eliminating Iran as a security threat—real, exaggerated or imagined. Given his track record on Palestinian rights, it is difficult to believe that his stated desire "to create the conditions for the brave Iranian people to cast off the yoke of tyranny" is based on principle rather than realpolitik. Trump, for his part, could be motivated by any number of impulses: to bask in US military power, command the limelight, distract from the ongoing Jeffrey Epstein scandal, generate economic returns or all of the above. Common decency seems least likely.

Wrong motivations do not necessarily exclude right outcomes. But the US and Israel must demonstrate here that their aggression will ultimately do more good than harm, which will not be easy. Neither has any discernible strategy for ending the war with clear net gains in regional and global security, let alone in internal human rights and democracy.

Achieving a favourable regime change through airpower alone is unlikely, as Nato's intervention in Libya in 2011 showed, and boots on the ground have done little better, as in Afghanistan and Iraq. Decapitating a regime may produce a successor more amenable to external actors, but just as authoritarian, as in Venezuela today.

There is huge discontent among Iranians, but effective organizational leadership has yet to emerge. Unless Iranian military leaders defect *en masse*, or cracks start appearing in the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps and other parts of the country's enormous and brutal security apparatus, those who take to the streets could face horribly dire consequences. Fighting to the last drop of the Iranian people's blood is hardly a morally attractive option. But it seems currently to be the only one on offer from the US.

There is one more hurdle to accepting this war as illegal but legitimate. What helped the argument in the Kosovo case was that those breaching the UN Charter did not treat the law that they were violating as irrelevant, but rather claimed—credibly—that they were doing so for exceptional and defensible reasons. The threat to international law lies not in its occasional breach—that happens in all legal systems, sometimes for the best of reasons—but in its contemptuous dismissal. And that is exactly how both Trump and Netanyahu have treated it throughout their time in office. As Trump told the *New York Times* in January, "I don't need international law," claiming that the only constraint on his power is "my own morality, my own mind."

This war of choice has not met the conditions it must to be considered morally legitimate. And based on what we have seen so far, Trump and Netanyahu face an uphill battle in arguing any such case.

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MINT CURATOR

The Iran war has amplified big risks faced by the US economy

America was already pushing limits when it decided to wage war

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America's public debt is testing its limit of sustainability. AFP

US President Donald J. Trump's extraordinary gamble in attacking Iran and risking a wider conflagration in West Asia dials up the economic hazards facing the US economy from 'very high'" to 'extreme.' This new stress compounds a series of other pressures already facing the economy, which is now even more unlikely to emerge unscathed.

The near danger is a setback in financial markets that gets out of hand. In many ways, some such reversal was already overdue, given the apparent overvaluation of US equities, the weight placed by tariffs on the economy's back, a still-deteriorating fiscal outlook and stubborn inflation. Add the risks of spiking energy prices, trade interruption and global political turbulence.

Inflation is a cause for concern. The core producer price index, which excludes food and energy, increased by 0.8% in January, markedly higher than expected. Its main components feed into the Fed's preferred metric, core PCE inflation. That's running at 3% in the year to December, still much higher than the Fed's 2% target. On Monday the Institute for Supply Management supplied more such evidence: It said the price of manufacturing inputs is rising at the fastest rate since 2022.

Energy inflation would arrive on top of this already-troubling prospect. Energy prices rose as the strikes on Iran began and analysts are contemplating oil at over $100 a barrel, up from $65 before the offensive. As always, there's a reassuring best-case scenario: If all goes well, a quick campaign followed by a power shift in Tehran might lift the threat of future conflict and improve confidence in the global energy infrastructure, which could bring oil prices lower than they were before. But if the conflict continues and widens, energy facilities comes under sustained attack and the Strait of Hormuz stays shut, $100 a barrel might be decidedly optimistic.

Echoes of the 1970s: A lasting spike in oil prices would mean stagflation: higher inflation plus slower growth, a combination that the Fed is powerless to defeat. Granted, the US is a now a net exporter of oil, so the domestic growth penalty would be less this time. But the shock would still be global, the net effect on the US would still be stagflationary and it would compound existing inflationary pressures.

Look at America's fiscal-policy backstop. Whether the US still has one is very much in question. Even before the Supreme Court overturned so-called reciprocal tariffs, the outlook for public borrowing was testing limits. Budget deficits at 6% of GDP, even with the economy at full employment and comfortably quiescent interest rates, mean that public debt will continue to grow faster than the economy. That's what 'unsustainable' means.

The tariff setback will deprive the US government of around $150 billion a year of expected revenue. It might also have to refund tariffs already collected. To make good the shortfall, Trump has announced a new global tariff of 10% rising to 15% under Section 122 of the 1974 Trade Act; he also promised 'investigations' that could lead to new taxes under other authorities – actions that threaten to upend trade deals with numerous partners. In short, the court's ruling guarantees two things: less revenue than previously expected, combined with even greater uncertainty about the future tariff regime.

Section 122 tariffs can only be imposed for 150 days without Congress's approval. They are probably illegal because their rationale—the need to address "fundamental international payments problems" including "large and serious balance-of-payments deficits"—arguably doesn't apply. The US has a big current-account deficit, financed by an equally big capital-account surplus, but no BoP gap. Other tools are legally questionable as well, because they mostly rely on some kind of urgent need to block trade.

Congress seems remarkably unconcerned about this presidential abuse of its trade laws. Having gifted these supposedly limited delegations of power to the White House, it now just watches as one bogus emergency follows another. But litigation has stepped up. The legal setback underlines the fragility of the broader tariff strategy. As long as import taxes can't be relied on and until Congress is forced to take budget control seriously, the revenue shortfall will worsen and high fiscal uncertainty will prevail. As a result, Washington will have little or no fiscal space [for a real crisis].

Uncertainty off the scale might be the hammer blow. At a certain point, confidence tested again could mean everything suddenly gives way. How much disruption can the US economy, for all its strengths, absorb? US trade and budget policies were already gambling with financial disaster. With the Iran strikes, the White House has doubled down again.

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MY VIEW | GENERAL DISEQUILIBRIUM

Solutions to India's external adversities reside at home

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If you thought 2025 was a tough transition, 2026 now seems to have plenty more surprises in store. India, in particular, has to trek through two tricky minefields over the next 10 months: energy security and technological flux. These two prickly issues will have to fight for the political leadership's mind-space, cluttered as it is with tricky geopolitics, rising unemployment, sticky economic growth and an always-on electoral cycle. There's another daunting challenge: dealing with a mercurial world leader with rapidly shifting objectives.

A face in Greek mythology is said to have launched a thousand ships. In contemporary times, there is a world leader who has been subjected to multiple names. US president Donald Trump has been called many things, especially in his second term, but the term 'neo-royalist' has gained much traction. In a *Foreign Affairs* article, Harvard University professor Stephen M. Walt called him a "predatory hegemon." There have been other appellations too: realist, isolationist, mercantilist, nationalist, imperialist. The list will definitely expand during the remainder of his presidency.

Immediately, though, America's unilateral attack on Iran may fetch Trump some more names, but they would be materially different from all the previous ones. This is because willy-nilly the conflict has multiple business dynamics at its core. The official reasons behind the Iran attacks, ostensibly at the prodding of Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, are still unclear with the goalposts being shifted every day: while one day it was obliterating Iran's nuclear capability, the next day it was regime change. But, through this all, somebody or some people are making a lot of money.

Take oil, a commodity that sees prices spike every time there is a conflict in West Asia. Spot Brent crude prices on the New York Mercantile Exchange have jumped by around 37% in less than three months. Brent is the benchmark for over 65% of the world's globally traded oil, which includes oil from the Gulf region. In sympathy, spot West Texas Intermediate prices—a benchmark for North American oil—also jumped over 37% during the same period, even though most of its originating oilfields are far removed from the conflict zone. Leading US oil company ConocoPhillips has seen its share price jump by 30% during the same period. Ditto for many other US-based oil companies. No prizes for guessing the winners here.

Here is an interesting aside. Trump and his officials promised to solve the looming oil shortage by declaring that the US navy would escort tankers through the narrow Strait of Hormuz, as well as pledging that US government agencies will underwrite political risk insurance for tankers. And then, just about when spot Brent crude prices were about to relent, a US submarine sank an Iranian warship on 4 March. The next morning, Brent crude price resumed its northward journey.

The government must focus on basic economic principles, job creation and private sector investment

The scent of a war has always benefitted defence company stock prices. Lockheed Martin, a leading US-based aerospace and defence technology company, has seen its stock price shoot up by over 50% in less than three months. The stock price of Northrop Grumman, another large defence contractor for the US government, is up by around 38%.

The war effort is quietly mining another goldfield. Columbia University professor Rajiv Sethi has been writing regularly about how anonymous punters have made tidy sums betting on prediction markets (such as, Polymarket or Kalshi) about the exact date of Nicolás Maduro's abduction or the precise dates of US strikes on Iran. News agency *Associated Press* reported mid-February that two Israelis had been charged for using classified information to place bets on future military operations (*tinyurl.com/y6hua84r*).

While all this points to a clear emerging trend (and perhaps deserving of an appropriate moniker), it makes planning and strategy a quagmire. In fact, whatever the motivations and rationales for the war, it has profound consequences for India's energy security. As an economy dependent on net imported petroleum products, India's dilemma will be whether to reach out to Russia again for cheaper oil, with full knowledge of the likely punitive consequences. There are multiple cost-benefit angles to consider when weighing, on one hand, cheaper oil from Russia coupled with probably higher US tariffs against more expensive oil from the US but lower import tariffs on the other. The big unknown here is the duration of the conflict. Add to this the artificial intelligence disruption coming down the road, which is likely to undermine India's services export capabilities, a crucial source of support for the country's balance of payments. In short, when added to the cumulative effect of elevated energy costs, weak capital flows and a currency under pressure, both inflation and growth rates are likely to feel the impact.

India will need to explore multiple scenarios to reinforce its economic and strategic security. In all economic negotiations over the past 30 years, India has used its market size and demographics as a bargaining chip. However, there are now signs that negotiators on the other side of the table see this as jejune and fraying.

It is clear that the government has to get back to basic economic principles and policies that prioritize private sector investment and domestic employment, away from a misplaced focus on sectarian politics.

How layoffs became fodder for memes

Memes about layoffs are changing not only how we perceive job loss, but also how we process it, often desensitizing us to the real repercussions

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The many memes are changing how we process job loss.

Hardik Shah is disoriented by the way layoffs unfold. Three years ago, he was laid off from a global social media company in its post-pandemic cull. "I had never even taken a break between jobs. Being laid off was brutal," recalls Shah from Mumbai who works as a CTO at a hospitality company now. "I deliberated for days before posting about it on LinkedIn," he says.

When Shah shared the news, the response surprised him. Referrals surfaced in the comments. Strangers reached out with empathy. "Before, referrals were sought only in private. After the purge, folks started talking openly and strangers helped." The scale of the layoffs had created a collective permission to speak.

What unsettles him now is the speed at which this tone has shifted; how most layoffs are now followed by a meme-fest, as if the punchlines are queued up alongside the official statement. "If you are confident and have a support system, you will shrug off the setback. If you don't, it will be painful and make you wonder why are jokes at your expense," says Shah, 43.

Last week captured this shift in a single frame. A meme began circulating on X: In one half of the frame was Jack Dorsey, former Twitter co-founder, now leading fintech company Block. On the other was *Game of Thrones* actor Peter Dinklage, dressed in identical black, beard trimmed in a similar style. Above Dorsey's head was the number 10,000, above Dinklage's, 6,000, followed by the kicker: "40% smaller".

The tweet, posted by @peer_rich, has since crossed two million impressions. It surfaced after Dorsey announced that Block would cut nearly 4,000 jobs, shrinking its workforce of over 10,000 to 6,000 in a sweep. Among related tweets, user @jamiegenerated, wrote that this will lead to a wave of reductions in tech, adding "layoffs spread like memes." The virality of the Dorsey-Dinklage post signals something equally concerning: layoffs are the memes now.

LAUGH IT OFF

The mass layoffs during covid shifted our outlook towards job loss. When thousands of jobs were cut at once, it softened the stigma and got many people posting publicly about it, leading to changes like LinkedIn making 'Open to Work' a template frame to use in profile pictures in June 2020. But somewhere along the way, as the rounds kept coming and companies brutally executed them, those affected as well as observing looked to humour for coping. Today, layoffs are one of many meme content formats, inadvertently desensitising people to scroll past what needs to be sat with. It is changing how we perceive and process job loss.

In India, in December 2024, YesMadam, a beauty services startup, pulled a 'pretend firing' publicity stunt. After floating what appeared to be an internal email suggesting staff had been fired over reporting workplace stress concerns, the company issued a press release revealing that no one had actually been dismissed and this was part of a marketing campaign intended to spark conversation about stress at work. YesMadam did not respond to *Lounge* queries sent on the subject.

It makes you wonder how we arrived at a point where layoffs could double as material for humour or marketing, anything other than the life-altering events they are meant to be, carrying anxiety, shaken morale, and very real financial and health consequences in their wake.

> Mass layoffs during covid shifted outlooks towards job loss. When thousands of jobs were cut, it softened the stigma.

Humour can, of course, be a coping mechanism. In January, when Amazon began its recent round of 16,000 job cuts, employees on a 26,000-person official Slack channel shared pizza memes, *Business Insider* reported. It was a reference to Jeff Bezos's "two-pizza team" rule, the idea that no team should be too large to be fed by two pizzas.

The current trend marks a stark departure from the way layoffs were historically understood and represented. In 1964, Satyajit Ray's *Mahanagar* built its entire emotional architecture around a husband's sudden unemployment, the quiet shame of it, the way it forced his wife into the workforce and undid the family's sense of itself. A decade later, *Roti Kapda Aur Makaan* (1974) made job loss a political act. In Japan, Kiyoshi Kurosawa's *Tokyo Sonata* (2008) followed a salaryman who loses his job and rides the train every day for months rather than tell his family. Hollywood's *Up in the Air* (2009) centred on the toll of job loss told through the gaze of a man in charge of delivering the news of layoffs. Even Bollywood's *Bewakoofiyan* (2014), starring Ayushmann Khurrana, while lighter in tone, uses a job loss to crack open ideas of love and pride. These films existed because job loss was the kind of event that required a reckoning.

You didn't just lose income. You lost a role, a version of yourself, so much so that it would take a film to contain it. Now it just takes a meme.

WAITING FOR CUTS

Shreya Panjwani, a clinical psychologist from Delhi, says, "Because you're repeatedly being exposed to layoff news and it's being turned into humour, it can blunt the emotional shock that a job loss can create. This kind of desensitisation doesn't necessarily reduce stress, it turns into a sense of chronic uncertainty for employees." Chronic uncertainty in turn becomes a stresser, notes Panjwani. "Employees become hypervigilant, wondering if they're going to be next."

A mid-level executive from Mumbai, who was laid off from Meta India in 2022, knows this well. "I was at my current company's event recently when my email app threw an error. My first thought: have I been laid off again? Colleagues confirmed in near real time that the error was a company-wide glitch. But even their thoughts were on the same lines even though none of them have ever been laid off," says the executive who prefers to stay anonymous.

For some, that reflex turns into a reset. Yash Agarwal, a public policy professional in his late 20s, found out he had lost his job at Twitter India in January 2023, after he was discharged from hospital following a health emergency. The experience rewired him. "I don't attach myself to places now, or people, roles, titles." The lesson arrived early for him: "You are a line item in someone's balance sheet."

Meanwhile, recruiters are watching the same shift from the other side of the table. K Sudarshan, MD India and regional chairman Asia at EMA Partners, a global executive search firm, points to the linguistic softening that accompanied this shift. "Nobody says fired anymore, they say 'let go'." The startup boom of the 2010s began normalising layoffs in India well before covid, he notes, but the candour remains uneven. "Indian companies are still far more tight-lipped than their US counterparts, who have learnt to package job cuts as a business strategy."

It isn't true for all industries either. In many sectors, Shah points out, people still don't announce layoffs. "In pharma, in manufacturing...you won't see senior leaders writing long posts about being laid off. It's still very hush-hush."

Within the Indian context, there's also "information asymmetry" at play, says Mitasha Singh, co-founder of All Things Talent, a talent acquisition and management firm in Bengaluru. "Traditional industries, service industries and older hierarchy-based professions, like lawyers, IAS officers, teachers, doctors, would not talk of layoffs in the same vein or as a matter-of-fact logical conclusion to demand-supply or differing values. Those who do are exceptions." What we see online is skewed by who is visible. "We're biased by the exposure we see within tech circles. For every person who creates content off it (layoff), there's a thousand more who don't."

Normalisation shouldn't lead to numbness. Companies need to do better. When Jack Dorsey announced Block's job cuts, he acknowledged the harshness of the decision and its impact on people's lives, saying the company was choosing to make the reductions in one go rather than in waves that prolong stress—a pattern seen across big tech in recent years. Some replies called it a "layoff announcement done right." Even as layoffs become easier to talk about in some sectors, the challenge now is to ensure they do not become easier to dismiss.

MONDAY MOTIVATION

The quiet power of starting the workday slow

Swizzle's Vrinda Singhal on the importance of prioritizing 'ruthlessly'

Shail Desai

Even as her batchmates were celebrating campus placements and job offers, Vrinda Singhal was working overtime figuring out the basics of running a start-up. Through entrepreneurs in her family, she was aware that the time ahead would be full of ups and downs.

"The risk was worth it because I knew that the guilt of passing the opportunity was going to far outweigh the guilt of failing. That was the way I looked at it—a learning curve as opposed to a gamble," says Bengaluru-based Singhal, 28, co-founder of Swizzle, a clean-label, ready-to-drink mocktail brand.

While studying the market, Singhal realised that most drinks were "either overly sugary or positioned too seriously as health products". Swizzle started out with cocktail kits for house parties. The use of real ingredients requires an efficient supply chain and inventory planning, while working closely with partners to ensure that quality is maintained. Singhal picked up a lot of the skills to tackle these challenges during her days as a student, studying information technology at the Bundelkhand Institute of Engineering and Technology, Jhansi. "Engineering trained me to think structurally, breaking big problems into smaller, solvable parts," she says.

Singhal talks to *Mint* about mentorship and why she feels at home in Bengaluru's Cubbon Park.

Who do you consider your mentor?

My brother, our investors, fellow founders and senior industry folks who've guided me at different stages.

> 'Separating thinking from execution sharpens efficiency at the workplace'

How do you mentor your colleagues at work?

Mentoring is about providing an environment where you can test things, where you can experiment and where you can learn. It's about being free to allow the team to own things, rather than micromanaging.

Productivity principles that have made your professional and personal life much easier?

Prioritising ruthlessly, saying "no" more often and blocking deep-work time on my calendar. I've learnt that separating thinking from execution sharpens efficiency at the workplace.

What's your morning schedule like?

I like starting slow—some quiet time and a 5,000-step walk that builds toward my goal of 10,000 steps a day. Before diving into calls, I map out my top three priorities.

How do you unwind?

I'm fond of music. On Sundays I usually spend time walking in Cubbon Park. Lately, I've become more intentional about boundaries, logging off at a fixed time and protecting Sundays for rest. It's helped me avoid burnout and be more productive.

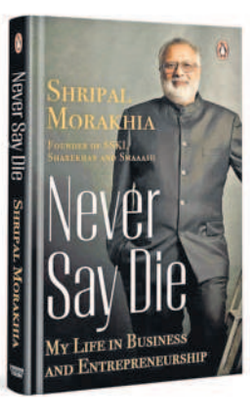
Monday Motivation *is a series in which business leaders discuss their mentors and work ethics.*

Write to us at feedback@livemint.com

EXTRACT

A thrilling road to building a gaming company

The journey of creating a bowling simulator that bridged the gap between amateur players and international stars



Never Say Die: My Life in Business and Entrepreneurship
By Shripal Morakhia, Penguin Random House India, 224 pages, ₹699

Shripal Morakhia

2010–2016: Clubs were elitist and out of reach. The lack of open space exacerbated by poor air quality left no healthy or sheltered places to play and develop emotional intelligence. This lacuna fostered the birth of Play-Live, which was later renamed Smaaash.

There were a few existing formats, but they lacked the neutrality of age and, most importantly, the application of modern available technology. Once, in 2011, while watching a cricket match, I saw the technology offered by Hawkeye and requested them to develop an expertise that would take indoor cricket to the next level.

At that time, Hawkeye was an independent company and they had the flexibility to move quickly. One-and-half-years of hard work followed which involved creating a special bowling simulator—that could bowl fast, swing, and spin; a ball that would not hurt and yet had the feel of a season ball, perfecting the tracking technology and placing the field using AI depending on the strength of one's shots as well as the opposing team's ability to do the field placement. The game was created at four levels to make it all-inclusive. Women, men, children, adults, grandparents, amateurs, beginners, and pros could all play and have fun together.

Fielders had four levels of intelligence. At a beginner level, he could drop a catch, but at an international level (pro level) his fielding would be compared to the best of fielders. Imagine Malinga bowling to your son at an amateur level, and he hits a stylish boundary that rolls past fielders, and then he looks at you for appreciation. The subsequent thumbs up and resounding ovation that he would get created a deep, unforgettable connection. That was the bond I was looking for. And this is how the first game of Smaaash was born. I was so excited that I invited Sachin Tendulkar and his family to try the simulator....

Sachin saw his son play and said, 'this is 99 per cent as good as real.' Next, we had lunch at a four-star Michelin restaurant [in London]... but I was not there for the food. It was the collaboration with the cricket legend that I was interested in. This is how the partnership with the great Sachin Tendulkar was born in England... I was in seventh heaven because the first two objectives of the company were achieved: You get to play with cricket stars regardless of your calibre. The God of Cricket... had agreed to partner with the venture.

Sachin Tendulkar at a World Cup cricket match in Port of Spain in 2007. REUTERS

I took it as a good omen. God was smiling upon me once again.

In 2012–2013, Star TV was bidding aggressively for BCCI cricket rights. Sony Entertainment, with whom I had investment banking connections, had IPL rights back then. These two channels seemed to be the best fit as partners to give a holistic cricket experience to their viewers...

I first sought a meeting with Sony and I was meeting the CEO after a long time. He was not enthused by what we had to offer, but I did not let that deter me. I sent an email to the CEO of Star TV and had to wait four weeks to meet their COO and the EA to the CEO. They were impressed with... what I had to offer.

The Star team was keen to sample an experience, but we did not have nets in India. I invited them to Winchester, where our prototype could be experienced. They were scheduled to visit Amsterdam in ten days for a trade fair of the International Broadcasting Association.

The CEO and COO were... impressed with the technology and requested me to set up the facility in Mumbai around the time their global boss, J.M., short for James Murdoch, was visiting Mumbai for a board meeting. They were clear that the buy-in would be done by J.M.

I was game to take the risk—because risk-taking was the only thing I knew. In a matter of two weeks, we not only set up the cricket lane, but also a few other technologies that we had perfected. This included our hologram technology where we filmed a Bharatanatyam dancer.

The set was in Rajkamal Studio, Mumbai. That morning, I had my heart in my mouth. This was a do-or-die moment for me. I had never had a big brother—a financial or strategic advisor—and this would be my first business in which I would have a solid partner to back my endeavours.

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